TKC Volume One — The World Dossier

Oct 23, 2026 · @Dany

How this volume works

Volume One is about the world: the history, institutions, beliefs and places that produced Eden's story. The people and the chapters belong to Volume Two. When a fact about the world matters to one particular person, this volume points to her dossier instead of working it out here.

The world parts (VI through XI) come first in this doc because you need the whole world in hand before you build chapters. They're written from your source files, your Final Rulings and the rulings you made in the calibration doc. Parts I through V, the scripture research, will be rewritten from the old Companion next and slot in ahead of them when the volume is assembled.

Reading the labels

Anything established by your files carries a source tag and no label. Everything else is labeled at the start of the sentence or paragraph it governs.

Tag	Source
TL	Timeline Updated
TR	The Covenant Trials Updated
TR-orig	The original Covenant Trials file. Used only where the updated file is silent, and superseded wherever they disagree.
DOM	The Dominions Update
MEN	Men in the Covenant Empire
CR	The Crownward
DR3	Draft Three (Chapter One so far)
WR	Writing Rules
FR 0–44	Final Rulings, by number

Tag	Source
AM	Audit Master (the old Companion)
Ruling	A ruling you made in the calibration doc on October 23

Label	Meaning
RESEARCH	Outside fact, with a source
INTERPRETATION	A reading of the material, offered as a reading
CONTESTED	A real scholarly or theological dispute
INFERENCE	A conclusion drawn from your files that they don't state
POSSIBLE	An idea worth considering. Not canon.
OPEN QUESTION	Something you still have to decide
CONFLICT	Two of your sources disagree
SUPERSEDED	Older material that no longer controls
DECIDED	A call you handed to me. Treated as canon until you overrule it.

Every part closes with working questions, and each one gets real room on the page. Bracketed design notes mark places where a visual would carry the information better than prose. Nothing here is designed yet. The doc exports to Word or PDF from its menu if you want a plain printed copy before the designed version exists.

Part VI. The Fall of the United States

The United States became the Covenant Empire of America over about eighteen years. It started with a stadium sermon in 2033 and ended in 2051, when the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast were written into the constitution as the three branches of government. Almost every step went through a vote, a referendum or an agreement (TL). Nobody in Eden's lifetime remembers the country before. The oldest person in her cast was born around 2035, into its last few years.

VI.1 The timeline

Year	Event	Source
2025–2031	The Fracture Years. A contested election leaves two men claiming the presidency at once. Automated labor wipes out forty percent of working-class jobs. Domestic attacks on federal buildings go uncontained, and a climate disaster makes the Gulf Coast uninhabitable. Faith in federal institutions collapses, and church attendance triples.	TL
2031	Evangelical megachurches, conservative political action groups and private militias organize as the Covenant Coalition. Their platform: "America was great when it was godly. Return to God. Return to greatness." They run candidates at every level of government at once.	TL
2033	Elias Vane, a little-known Georgia preacher, preaches *Thy Kingdom Come* for six hours to 400,000 people at The Gathering House, the former Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta. Every Coalition network carries it live.	TL
2035	Vane wins a Senate seat from Georgia. Within eighteen months he effectively controls the legislative agenda.	TL
c. 2035	Celeste Parish born	INFERENCE from TL
2039	California, Oregon and New York attempt to secede. The Coalition-controlled federal government calls it treason, and a two-year standoff follows.	TL
2041	The Partition Agreement brings the three states back with "regional autonomy." The autonomy is dismantled about four years later. Vane authors the Restoration Act, which passes Congress narrowly, under conditions later described as coercion.	TL

Year	Event	Source
2043	Vane declares the United States dissolved and reborn as the Covenant Empire of America. He takes the title First Elector. The Crownward is formally established over Washington, D.C.	TL, CR
2044	The Dominion Act reorganizes the states into Twelve Dominions, each under a Governor-Prelate. Atlanta becomes Aurelia, seat of the Dominion of Aurem.	TL
2048	Elias Vane, 52, marries Sera Callum, 28, a Vowed woman and Temple scholar. It's the first Anointed marriage.	TL
2051	The Triune Rule makes the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast the three constitutional governing bodies.	TL
2054	Vane becomes Emperor by a referendum that returns 94 percent approval. He founds the House of Vane.	TL
2058	The Commonwife quota system is piloted in Red Earth.	DOM
2061	Elias Vane dies of heart failure at 65. The Temple canonizes him within the year. His face goes on the currency, and his sermon becomes required curriculum in every Dominion school. The same year, Elias's elder child, the rightful successor and Dorian's parent, is removed.	TL, FR 35–36
2062	Crest Vane takes the throne at 34. The Commonwife quotas are introduced, and the Ungoverned are designated criminal.	TL
2065	The first Covenant Trials	TL
2077	Azrael Vane born	TL
2079	Judah Vane born	TL
2085	Crest dies mid-cycle. Dorian takes the throne at 40, and that year's Trial is cancelled.	TL, FR 39

Year	Event	Source
2098	Azrael, 21, finds a ledger in the east wing archive	TL
2100	Azrael is officially declared dead. The ledger and the Covenant of Dissent vanish the same week.	TL
2104	The 39th Covenant Trial	TL

CONFLICT: The timeline introduces the Commonwife quotas under Crest in 2062, and the Dominions file says Red Earth piloted them in 2058. INFERENCE: Both can be true if the 2058 pilot ran under Elias in one Dominion and Crest took it Empire-wide in 2062.

[DESIGN NOTE: This could become a two-page horizontal timeline, with the Fracture Years shaded as one band and the four rulers marked along the bottom.]

VI.2 How the Empire tells it, and what the record shows

Everyone in Eden's world learned the left column in school. Where a character sits between the two columns says a lot about who she is. The Empire's phrasing is also what people would actually say out loud, so it's the version to use in dialogue (AM).

What the Empire calls it	What happened
The Fracture Years, which God ended	Six years of overlapping disasters that a well-organized coalition was ready to inherit
The Restoration	A 400-page law that made rights conditional, passed under coercion nobody had to name
Regional autonomy, granted in mercy	A four-year holding pattern for three states that tried to leave, dismantled once the leverage was gone
Public mandate, 94 percent	A referendum controlled tightly enough to produce the number it wanted
Reorganized for accuracy and unity	The press became a branch of government
Citizenship clarified through covenant	A woman's legal standing became dependent on whether a man has married her

What the Empire calls it	What happened
A celebration of the Empire's finest women	A televised selection that produces one Anointed Wife a year, and eleven women married down the elite ladder (FR 19)
A sudden medical event	The phrase the Empire uses for Azrael in 2100 and for Petra in 2104

[DESIGN NOTE: Side-by-side comparison here: OFFICIAL VERSION / LIVED REALITY.]

VI.3 The Restoration Act

The Restoration Act of 2041 is the legal root of almost everything in Eden's life. The timeline gives four things it did (TL).

- **Rights become conditional.** They depend on standing, compliance and designation.
- **Marriage becomes a legal and theological designation.** The Binding, the Commonwife quota and the Anointed marriage all descend from this line.
- **Women's citizenship is reclassified as dependent on marital status.** This is why Unbound is a legal category with a file and not a description of someone's life.
- **The press is "reorganized for accuracy and unity."** Ten years later the same apparatus is a branch of government, and today it controls forty percent of a Covenant Daughter's score.

The act passed Congress, so the Empire's founding argument is that nothing illegal happened (TL).

OPEN QUESTION: What does the Act's preamble say? You'll want the actual wording for any scene where a character quotes the Restoration.

VI.4 Living memory

Nobody in the cast lived through the Fall as an adult. What survives comes down through grandmothers and through the House of Vane's own documents.

Celeste Parish (TL). She was about nine in 2044 and remembers the renaming of Atlanta. She remembers her own grandmother crying when they changed the signs. She watched the Empire take her mother's identity through a Commonwife marriage, then raised Miriam alone under Unbound designation rather than let it happen again. The real name of the city is the last thing she says to Eden before the Crownward. (Volume Two, Celeste.)

Sera Montoya's grandmother (TR). She was at the last protest before the Partition Agreement ended Pacific's resistance in 2041. She tells it to Sera as a warning, not a hero story: the difference between impact and loss is knowing when and how. (Volume Two, Sera.)

Pacific's generations (DOM). The people who remember trying to leave raised children who grew up with parents who'd tried and failed. Their grandchildren grew up knowing the story. The Empire still checks every Pacific girl's Designation for signs that the secession story survived in her.

Zara Voss's grandmother (TR). She has a real name the desert knows and the Empire doesn't. She raised Zara in Sable Reach and in the desert beyond it. (Volume Two, Zara.)

The House of Vane (TL, FR 35–44). The family keeps documents instead of grandmothers' stories, and those documents are the most dangerous things in the Crownward. See VI.5.

VI.5 Founder files

Elias Vane (c. 1996–2061). A relatively unknown Georgia preacher until the 2033 sermon (TL). His dates put his birth around 1996 (INFERENCE, from his ages in 2048, 2054 and 2061). He won his Senate seat in 2035, authored the Restoration Act in 2041, became First Elector in 2043 and Emperor in 2054, and died in 2061. The Temple canonized him within a year. His face is on the currency, and *Thy Kingdom Come* is required curriculum in every Dominion school. The Temple teaches that God chose him specifically to restore the nation and that his descendants carry that anointing forward (CR).

INTERPRETATION: The old Companion's reading of his method still holds. He never took anything until refusing him would cost more than giving in. He ran candidates everywhere, made himself the man every faction needed, outlasted the secession instead of winning it, and wrote the law himself (AM).

Sera Callum Vane. A Vowed woman and Temple scholar who married Elias in 2048, when she was 28. She became the most powerful woman in the Empire's history while appearing entirely devoted to her husband. She wrote most of his domestic policy, and no official record says so (TL). Her marriage is the template for the Covenant Trials.

CONFLICT: The timeline says she came from "the Northern Dominion." None of the Twelve Dominions has that name.

Crest Vane (Emperor 2062–2085). Elias's son. He took the throne at 34, so he was born around 2028, twenty years before his father's Anointed marriage (INFERENCE). He's cold and procedural. He manages people instead of inspiring them, and under him the Empire

grows both more efficient and more brutal (TL). He introduced the Commonwife quotas, criminalized the Ungoverned and created the Trials. His claim came through survivorship, not birth order (FR 35, 39). He knew about his elder sibling's removal, didn't arrange it and didn't prevent it (FR 37). The one thing he did was preserve the documents, leaving them where the east wing archive would someday be inventoried (FR 40).

The removed heir. Elias's elder child, and the rightful successor. Removed in 2061, when Dorian was still a child (FR 35–36).

Dorian Vane (Emperor since 2085). The removed heir's son. He took the throne at 40 and is 59 in 2104 (TL, Ruling). He was spared because a child's claim can be supervised. Removing him would have needed a public reason, while raising him inside the house needed none (FR 38). He has known since 2061 that the documents name Elias (FR 44). Under him the Broadcast became genuinely sophisticated, and the Trials became the most-watched event of the year (TL).

OPEN QUESTION: Who was the mother of Elias's children? Crest was born about twenty years before Sera Callum, and his elder sibling earlier still.

SUPERSEDED: The Crownward file gives Dorian's age as 61. Your ruling uses 59, which matches the timeline and the Audit Master.

The ledger and the Covenant of Dissent (TL, FR 40–44). In 2098, during a Crown advisory access period, Azrael found a ledger in the east wing archive. It ties the Empire's founding documents to a series of deliberate removals, which the Covenant of Purpose describes as God's order and the ledger describes as something else. It had sat there unmoved since 2085, because nobody was looking (FR 41). He took it to his father, who told him to put it back. Azrael kept it and went looking for its companion, the Covenant of Dissent. Elias wrote it in the same year, in the same hand, as the theological counter-argument to everything the Empire was built on.

Dorian removed both documents the week Azrael was declared dead (FR 42). He told Azrael to put the ledger back because a document Azrael had read and returned would be one Dorian controlled. Destroying it would have told Azrael it mattered (FR 43).

[DESIGN NOTE: Use a family tree here, covering Elias, his unknown first wife, the removed heir, Crest, Dorian and Lyris, and Azrael and Judah, with the 2061 removal marked.]

Working questions

1. What exactly were the "deliberate removals" in the ledger: people, populations, records, or all three?

2. What does the Covenant of Dissent argue, in a sentence Elias could have preached? Why did he write it: doubt, insurance, vanity, or something else?
3. What did the removed heir know or do that made removal necessary in 2061? FR 35–38 cover how it happened and why Dorian was spared, but not why the heir had to go.
4. Who was Elias's first wife, and how does the Empire's official history treat her?
5. Where did Sera Callum come from, if not a "Northern Dominion"?
6. What does the Restoration Act's preamble say?
7. How do schools in Pacific teach the Partition, and how does that differ from what Pacific grandmothers say at home?
8. What did Celeste's grandmother lose when the signs changed? Who was she before the Fall?
9. Which lines from the 2033 sermon does every schoolchild know by heart?

[DESIGN NOTE: A full-page handwriting workspace after these questions.]

Part VII. The Covenant Empire: government and institutions

The Empire is run by three constitutional bodies: the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast. That arrangement is the Triune Rule of 2051 (TL). Underneath them sit twelve Dominions, each under a Governor-Prelate, along with a Registry that holds everyone's paper and a Vowed order that watches everyone's daughters. This part covers how those pieces fit together and where each one shows up in the book.

VII.1 The Triune Rule

In 2051 the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast were made the three governing bodies of the Empire. What had worked informally since 2043 became constitutional, and the Broadcast stopped being a network of Coalition media companies and became a branch of government (TL).

The three bodies split the Covenant Trials between them. The Temple runs Phase One and the Crown runs Phase Two. Endurance belongs to the terrain. The Covenant Score is weighted 30 percent Temple, 30 percent Crown and 40 percent Broadcast (TR). The Broadcast's share is never disclosed, because the public would be angry to learn that a broadcaster outweighs the Church in choosing the Empire's most powerful woman (TR).

[DESIGN NOTE: Org chart here: the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast across the top, with the Governor-Prelates, the Registry, the Vowed and the Covenant Court beneath them.]

VII.2 The Crown and the House of Vane

Every Emperor is a descendant of Elias Vane, who founded the House of Vane in 2054 (TL). The Temple teaches that God chose Elias to restore the nation and that the Vane bloodline carries that anointing forward. The family's status is theological, not just political (CR).

Ruler	Years	How he held power	Source
Elias Vane	First Elector 2043, Emperor 2054–2061	Belief. A preacher who made people want what he wanted.	TL, AM
Crest Vane	2062–2085	Procedure: quotas, designations, criminal categories and the Trials	TL
Dorian Vane	2085 to now. 59 in 2104.	Performance. He brought back the spectacle and made the Trials the year's biggest event.	TL, Ruling
Judah Elijah Vane	Crown Heir, 25 in 2104	Not yet. Raised by the Temple as much as by his parents.	TL

Succession runs by survivorship and the absence of any other recognized claimant (FR 39). Crest inherited after his elder sibling was removed in 2061. Dorian, that sibling's son, inherited after Crest died (FR 35, 39). When Azrael was declared dead in 2100, the line passed to Judah (TL).

SUPERSEDED: The Crownward file calls Crest Dorian's father. Under FR 35, Crest is Dorian's uncle.

The Crown Heir's marriage is a matter of state. Dorian has pushed Judah toward an Anointed Wife since Judah turned 23, because an unmarried heir is an heir whose loyalties are still unwritten (CR). Elite men usually marry between 25 and 35. The Trials exist partly because of Judah's reluctance, to make the choice feel like an honor instead of pressure (MEN). Young members of the House take part in "Crown advisory access periods," which is how Azrael got legitimate access to the east wing archive (TL, FR 41).

Lyris Vane is 58. She's the Empress and the most sophisticated political operator in the Empire, and she's spent thirty years performing perfect Anointed Wifehood while running the Crownward's domestic and diplomatic machinery. She lobbied through Dorian for a decade to shape the Anointed Wife's legal protections, and she framed every gain as his gift (CR). She came from Mountain Dominion (WR). (Volume Two, Lyris.)

VII.3 The Crownward

The Crownward is the capital, built over Washington, D.C. and formally established in 2043. Elias chose to occupy the old capital instead of moving it, because you don't abandon the seat of the thing you claim to restore (CR). Most people in 2104 have never seen a photograph of Washington (CR).

The Potomac is now the Covenant River, and it divides the city (CR).

- **The Sovereign Side (west bank)** is where power lives: white stone, dark iron and formal rows of magnolias. The Crown Palace sits at its highest point. The Temple Sanctum stands at a right angle to it, joined by a covered walkway called the Covenant Bridge. The Broadcast Citadel sits on the northern edge, placed so its cameras can see the Palace and the Sanctum at once. Sovereign Boulevard runs half a mile from the Palace gates to the river, lined with Broadcast screens that show the Covenant Scores during Trial season. Covenant Row runs parallel to it and holds the twelve Covenant Houses, one per Dominion.
- **The Administrative Side (east bank)** is where the Empire does its actual work. It holds the Covenant Court's offices, the Crown's administrative apparatus, staff housing, the Vowed training facilities, the registration bureaus and the Registry. It also has market streets, Temple-adjacent schools and small restaurants serving food from across the Dominions.
- **Three bridges** cross the river. The Sovereign Bridge is the widest and appears on the currency. The Covenant Bridge, the river one, is narrower and used by staff. The Grace Bridge is the oldest, never fully renovated, and has blind spots in Broadcast coverage, so it's where people go when they don't want to be filmed.

RESEARCH: In the real city, central Washington sits on the Potomac's east bank, and the west bank is Arlington, Virginia. Read literally, the Sovereign Side stands where Arlington National Cemetery and the Pentagon are now.

POSSIBLE: Somebody in the Crownward knows the Crown Palace is built over the old national cemetery.

The Crownward has a rigid social order that nobody writes down and everybody enforces (CR). The House of Vane is at the top. Below it is the Anointed Court, about forty families whose standing is measured by how close they live to the Palace, and who must attend quarterly audiences with the Emperor. Below them is the Administrative Class, the senior staff of the Crown, Temple and Broadcast, most of whose wives hold Stewardwife designation. The Crownward's daughters who enter the Trials are rarely the most celebrated candidates, and they're almost always the most dangerous (CR).

[DESIGN NOTE: Map needed here: the Covenant River, both banks, the three bridges, the Palace, the Sanctum, the Citadel, Sovereign Boulevard, Covenant Row and the Registry.]

VII.4 The Temple and the Vowed

The Temple is both a church and a branch of government. In Eden's world it shows up as ministers, Vowed women and doctrine. Its scripture is read from a book called the Book of Covenant (DR3), and the Temple Sanctum in the Crownward is its seat (CR).

Ministers. Senior Minister Bell is the model: a man who signs Binding certificates, sponsors Assessment candidates, and prays God will close every door not intended for a girl (DR3). The Temple High Prelates sit in the Anointed Court (CR).

The Vowed. These are women in Temple service, and they run most of the Empire's contact with women. A Vowed officer assesses every Aurem girl at eighteen (DOM). Vowed officers conduct the quarterly household assessments in Aurem's Commonwife households (MEN), run the Regional Assessments (TR), and observe, examine and interview the Covenant Daughters (TR). The Crownward Vowed are the Temple's elite. They're also the Empire's most efficient intelligence network. The Temple calls it spiritual discernment and the Crown uses it as surveillance, and it's never written down anywhere the Empire could confiscate it (CR). In Red Earth, Vowed officers attend school performances as "pastoral care" (DOM).

The Vowed designation can be left behind through marriage. Delphine's mother went from Vowed to Bonded Wife, and Hannah was Vowed before she became House Mother (TR, FR 30). Sera Callum was Vowed when Elias married her (TL). Girls train through a Vowed education program, which Hannah's daughter Naomi has one year left in (TL).

The Prelate. She heads the Crownward's Vowed. She's 67, has served three Emperors, and is the most institutionally knowledgeable person in the city about how power actually works. She assessed Judah's spiritual formation personally. In the first week of the Trial she'll reach a conclusion about Eden that she shares with no one, the Emperor included (CR). She anoints the Crown Heir's bride (CR). The files call her Prelate Naomi, but FR 33 renames her so Hannah's daughter can keep the name.

POSSIBLE: "Prelate Aurelia" is the working name until you choose one (FR, closing note).

VII.5 The Broadcast

The Broadcast is the Empire's state media and its third branch of government. Its Citadel stands in the Crownward (CR), and its studios, the ones where Trial scores are announced, sit in old Midtown Manhattan in Saint Meridian, the Empire's Broadcast

capital (DOM). It holds 40 percent of the Covenant Score. Its share includes "narrative priority decisions" by the Broadcast Director that shift weight toward the candidates it favors (TR). It edits the Civic Debates for Dominion release and builds a story around every candidate in real time (TR, CR). When a candidate's intelligence becomes the story instead of her compliance, it runs the "Eve narrative," which implies and never accuses (TR). See Part XI.

VII.6 Governor-Prelates and the Dominions

Each Dominion is governed by a Governor-Prelate, a single political and religious office (TL). Governor-Prelates choose each Dominion's Covenant Daughter from the top three of the Regional Assessment, and in practice they take whoever the Crown has quietly signaled it prefers (TR). How much each one actually controls varies a lot (DOM).

- Gulf's first Governor-Prelate lasted fourteen months.
- Lone's has always been born in Texas and has more independence than the rest.
- Pacific's was personally appointed by Dorian.
- Ardenne's has mostly stopped trying to fix the marriage records from outside Ashford.

See Part X.

VII.7 The Registry, the law and the paperwork

The Registry, on the Administrative Side, holds every citizen's Imperial record: birth designations, marriage registrations, Covenant Scores, Designation results and death records. Only the Crown Palace is guarded more heavily. Whoever controls what the Registry says about you controls something more basic than law, faith or the Broadcast (CR). Eden will understand this before most people in the story (CR).

Imperial law is interpreted by the Covenant Court. It keeps offices on the Administrative Side and secondary chambers in Blessed Shore, where the law "gets interpreted, refined, and weaponized" (CR, DOM).

In daily life the law arrives as forms.

- Household forms demand an adult male authority. Celeste wrote "deceased" on the line, and the form came back with the word circled and a request for the next adult male (DR3).
- A woman reclassifying her household under her own registration has to prove the arrangement is permanent (TL).

- Moving between Dominions requires Crown authorization. It's technically available and practically difficult (MEN).
- Any Ungoverned citation disqualifies a woman from the Covenant Registry (TR).
- Deaths are registered within 48 hours in the Crownward and within 24 in Meridian (CR, DOM).

OPEN QUESTION: What does an Ungoverned citation actually do to a person beyond disqualifying her? Is it criminal record, designation, or both?

VII.8 Surveillance

Cameras and Broadcast screens are everywhere in the seat cities. The Covenant Houses are wired in every common area, entrance and garden, but not the bedrooms. Leaving bedrooms unwatched is a deliberate choice to give candidates the illusion of privacy, which keeps them manageable (CR). Pacific has more cameras per block than any other Dominion (DOM). Red Earth embeds its Vowed in community life (DOM).

Records can be flagged. Eden's file reads "Exceptional intellect. Monitor closely," later updated to "Selected for Trial. Monitor closely" (TL). Sera's file was flagged before she arrived (TL).

The gaps are just as much a part of the world: the Grace Bridge (CR), the hollows of Ardenne (DOM), the Sable desert (DOM), west Lone's distances (DOM), and Saint Meridian's density (DOM). Endurance in Mountain terrain runs mostly without cameras (TR).

VII.9 Men, labor and the economy

The Empire controls women through designation and men through structure. Men are told they're free, and the control sits in housing, careers and marriage approvals (MEN).

Class	Who they are	Marriage	Source
Common men	The labor and service class, registered to their Dominion	Expected by 21. Unmarried men past 22 stay in labor dormitories. They marry within their caste and region.	MEN

Class	Who they are	Marriage	Source
Bonded men	Mid-tier administrators and skilled professionals, steered by Crown labor allocation	Between 21 and 25, from Unbound and Commonwife-eligible women, with Crown approval of the match	MEN
Covenant men	Elite: Crown officers, Temple leadership, Broadcast directors, senior military	Between 25 and 35. Their wives are Anointed.	MEN
Conscript men	Common boys whose scores flag them. Officially they don't exist.	Crown approval required at the Covenant Man level, for life	MEN

A common boy whose Designation scores come back exceptional gets a visit from a Crown education officer within three months, offering a scholarship to the Imperial Education Track. The family can decline. Declining routes the boy to the worst labor assignments for the rest of his life. Accepting makes him Crown-adjacent for life (MEN). (Volume Two, Solomon.)

At 18, common men register a Covenant Declaration with the Crown: a public statement of loyalty and readiness for service and marriage. Elite men register theirs when they finish the Imperial Education Track (MEN). Every Dominion layers its own rites over it. See Part VIII.4.

Each Dominion has its own economy (DOM).

- Irongate: manufacturing
- Lone: oil and space infrastructure
- Mountain: classified operations, resource extraction and military capacity
- Gulf: tourism, rebranded as "cultural pilgrimage"
- Meridian: law and administration
- Vane: the Broadcast

INFERENCE: The forty percent of working-class jobs lost to automation during the Fracture Years never came back. That's what makes Imperial service look like opportunity to a common man.

Working questions

1. Who sits on the Trials Commission, and is it the same body as the TR file's "joint oversight committee"?
2. What does the Book of Covenant contain? Is it a full Bible, an edited one, or a separate collection with the Empire's own texts added?
3. What does it mean, legally, to be designated Ungoverned? What happens to a woman's children?
4. What does a Crown advisory access period involve, and who else in the House of Vane has had one?
5. How did Lyris, a woman from Mountain Dominion, become Dorian's wife? What did the Trials have to do with it, if anything?
6. What will the Prelate conclude about Eden in the first week, and what will she do with it?
7. What does a Stewardwife in the Administrative Class know that an Anointed Wife doesn't?
8. What can someone on the Grace Bridge do that they can't do anywhere else?
9. Who runs the Registry, and who has ever changed what it says about a person?
10. How does an Aurem common man get Crown authorization to move to another Dominion? How often is it actually granted?

[DESIGN NOTE: A full-page handwriting workspace after these questions.]

Part VIII. Doctrine and lived religion

The Temple's official religion fits in one line. Private religion lives in kitchens, back rooms, deserts and mountains, and it's different in every Dominion. This part covers what the Temple teaches, what texts it rests on, how it uses scripture, and what people actually practice that the Empire doesn't know about or has decided to tolerate.

VIII.1 What the Temple teaches

The official theology of marriage is the center of it: "the husband leads, the wife supports, the household reflects divine order in miniature." It's preached every week in every Temple, taught from the time children can read, and assumed by every law that governs women (CR). See Part IX.

The rest of the official teaching comes through in what the files show the Temple saying.

- **The Vane anointing.** The Temple teaches that God chose Elias to restore the nation and that the Vane bloodline carries divine sanction (CR). Elias was canonized within a year of his death, "not quite sainthood but close enough" (TL).
- **The House judges fairly.** Bell tells Celeste "The House always judges fairly," and Celeste answers "The House calls whom it calls" (DR3). Before scores are revealed, Bell speaks about "divine order, talent as stewardship, and elevation as burden." He closes with "May every daughter receive with grace the portion appointed to her" (DR3).
- **The House virtues.** The banners in the Aurelia Temple atrium read obedience, discernment, modesty, stewardship and endurance (DR3).
- **Selection as revelation.** The Broadcast frames the Trials as a revelation and never as a competition, using words like anointing, covenant, calling, worthy and chosen. A competition can be rigged, while a revelation can't be (TR).
- **Being Bound as service.** "Every girl in Aurem wanted to be Bound. It was the only way they knew how to serve" (DR3). Covenant Candidacy is "the closest thing a woman could get to godliness" (DR3).

VIII.2 The founding texts

The sermon, *Thy Kingdom Come* (2033). Six hours long, preached by Elias Vane at The Gathering House. Since 2061 it has been required curriculum in every Dominion school (TL). It's named for the line of the Lord's Prayer that the Empire was built on. The novel takes its title from the same words.

INTERPRETATION: The old Companion reads the sermon as a familiar prayer taken literally in public for the first time, and that reading is useful. Nobody in the stadium heard a coup. They heard their own prayer said aloud by a man who wasn't embarrassed by it (AM).

The Covenant of Purpose. A founding document of the Empire. It describes a series of deliberate removals as God's order, and the east wing ledger describes the same removals as something else (TL). Celeste can recite it (AM, Celeste dossier).

The Covenant of Dissent. Written by Elias in the same hand and the same year as the Empire's founding, as the theological counter-argument to everything the Empire was built on. It was catalogued in library holdings until 2100, when it disappeared the same week as the ledger (TL). Judah has been looking for it since before his brother's exile (TL).

The Book of Covenant. The book Bell reads from at the Assessment. It includes Proverbs 31:29, "Many daughters have done virtuously, but thou excellest them all," in King James wording (DR3).

OPEN QUESTION: Is the Book of Covenant the full Protestant Bible, an abridged edition (see Volume I, Part V on the 1807 Slave Bible), or scripture bound together with the Empire's own founding texts?

VIII.3 Scripture in the Empire's hands

Draft Three shows the method directly. The Assessment's doctrine section turns scripture into House policy (DR3).

Passage	What the Assessment made of it
"Honor thy father and thy mother" (Exodus 20:12)	A question about reporting an Unbound woman who housed her children without male authority
The widow's oil (2 Kings 4)	An argument for household rationing
Esther's crown	Proof that a woman could influence government, "so long as she was beautiful, obedient, and prepared to die for the privilege"
Proverbs 31	The verse printed on the first page of the Assessment and read aloud before the scores

Eden's own read on this: "Facts might earn professional placement. Knowing which facts the House needed her to believe could carry her farther" (DR3).

Your Writing Rules ask that biblical truth in the narration be accurate and that the Empire's distortions be deliberate (WR 38–42). The research behind that line lives in Parts I–V. The household code (Ephesians 5) entry is already drafted in the calibration doc.

VIII.4 Lived religion: what people actually practice

In every Dominion, people do things around the official rites that the Empire either doesn't know about, tolerates because stopping them would cost too much, or eventually approves because it already lost (DOM, MEN).

Dominion	Practice	What it is	The Empire's position
Aurem	The Salt Ceremony	The bride's mother or grandmother washes her hands in salt water the night before her Binding and tells her the truth about marriage	Doesn't know it exists
Aurem	The old way of burial	Three days, family-led, no Empire officiant: the Telling, the Feeding, the Release. Red clay packed down by family hands.	Doesn't know; the paperwork is filed anyway
Aurem	The Speaking	The night before a boy's Covenant Declaration, each man present tells him one true thing about being a man in Aurelia. The boy can't speak.	Unregulated
Aurem	Kitchens	Recipes that "looked like submission and tasted like memory." Women cook what they don't write down.	Never thought the kitchen was worth watching
Gulf	Music in worship	Live music at Bindings, against three ordinances, classed as "ceremonial expression within approved parameters"	Tolerated for tourism money
Gulf	The Last Free Night	The women of the family dance, drink and tell the bride the truth the night before her Binding	Never on paper
Gulf	The Procession	At 14, girls walk the boulevard in white, and the crowd turns it into a second line	Can't be stopped without a Broadcast incident

Dominion	Practice	What it is	The Empire's position
Gulf	Funerals	Three days of open house, a second line to the grave, then the Quiet, one hour of complete silence	Approved in 2052
Ardenne	Hollow marriages	A community declaration and a broom jump	Records left incomplete
Ardenne	The First Winter Work and the Sitting	A real job in the community's survival at 13 or 14. Sitting with the dead through the night.	Unregulated
Meridian	Reading Circles	Officially Temple Bible studies. Actually a legal-literacy network for Stewardwives, running since 2069.	Doesn't know what they are
Meridian	The record	Before his Declaration, a father walks his son through the family's complete Imperial record	Within the rules
Vane	Ghost Marriages and the Ghost Declaration	Unions outside registration, and a boy's private statement of what he actually intends	Doesn't know they exist
Irongate	The Kitchen	The women's mutual aid network	Never mapped by the Vowed
Irongate	The Placement and the First Shift	Community assessments of a girl's work at 14 and a boy's first adult shift at 18	Unregulated
Irongate	Music	Blues and jazz, classed "morally ambiguous musical forms" in 2053	Officially suppressed, survives underground

Dominion	Practice	What it is	The Empire's position
Heartland	The Anointing	The women wash and braid the bride's hair, each speaking a private word over her	"The most tender thing the Empire accidentally preserved"
Heartland	Planting	After a burial the community plants something that will come back	Approved in 2058
Red Earth	The Second Covenant	The morning after a Binding, a mother tells her daughter what the first covenant means and what she's allowed to keep for herself	Unrecorded, word for word across the Dominion
Red Earth	Score coaching	For twenty years mothers have taught high-scoring sons how much ability to show	Never documented
Red Earth	Sitting with the dead	Women sit with the body in shifts, and burial is at midday	Never understood, so never regulated
Lone	The Giving and the First Ride	The bride receives something of her grandmother's. A girl navigates a long distance alone.	Never acknowledged
Lone	Boots	The dead are buried with boots on	Approved without being understood
Mountain	The Witness Walk	A couple walks alone in the mountains before the ceremony	Unregulated
Mountain	The name to the mountain	A death prayer said once, with the name spoken to the mountain itself	Unregulated

Dominion	Practice	What it is	The Empire's position
Sable	Desert names	Every woman has two names, one for the Empire and one for the house. A girl earns hers at the Finding.	Doesn't know they exist
Sable	The Desert Walk and fire burials	A couple's night alone in the desert. The name said once into a fire that's left to burn out.	Unregulated
Pacific	The Real Binding	A private ceremony with the promises the couple actually means	Unregistered
Pacific	Facing West	A boy faces the ocean at dawn, then turns back to the city. The dead are buried facing west.	Burial rules ignored until the Empire gave up in 2078

INFERENCE: Where the files don't say how the Empire treats a practice, the last column reads "Unregulated." The files give no sign the Empire has noticed those practices, but they never say so outright.

INTERPRETATION: A pattern runs through the table. The Empire approves what it's already lost (Gulf funerals, Heartland planting), and it tolerates what makes money (Gulf music). What women do in kitchens, at bedsides and the night before a wedding mostly goes unseen, because the Empire never thought those places were worth watching. Celeste's whole faith is built in that blind spot.

[DESIGN NOTE: This table could become a two-page spread grouped by rite of passage (marriage, coming of age, death) with the twelve Dominions as columns.]

VIII.5 Faith that isn't performance

The files are careful not to make every believer a dupe. Heartland faith is genuine, and real believers "have opinions about what faithfulness actually requires" (DOM). Heartland women questioning the Commonwife designation call it theological inquiry, and they mean it (DOM). Ruth Gideon "believes the Empire more than Eden does," and she's

sincere without being foolish (WR 26). Eden's own faith is real and "required more maintenance" than Maribel Vale's (DR3). Celeste is, by the old dossier's description, the most religious person in the book and the least Imperial (AM).

INTERPRETATION: The novel's religious line doesn't run between belief and unbelief. It runs between faith the Temple can use and faith that answers to something the Temple doesn't control.

Working questions

1. What does the Covenant of Purpose actually say? Write the passage about the removals in the Empire's own voice.
2. What does the Covenant of Dissent argue, and which line in it would get someone arrested today?
3. What is the Empire's official text of the Lord's Prayer? Has anything been cut, added or re-translated?
4. Which verses are carved over the doors of the Aurelia Temple and the Temple Sanctum?
5. What happens to a woman caught performing a Salt Ceremony, if anyone ever has been?
6. Has Eden attended a Salt Ceremony, or only heard about one? Has she seen an old-way burial?
7. What did the men tell Zion at his Speaking? Pick one line Eden will never hear.
8. Is there an Aurem equivalent of Meridian's Reading Circles or Irongate's Kitchen, a network of women that Celeste belongs to?
9. What hymns does the Temple approve, and what do people sing in the outer districts instead?
10. What does a Heartland woman's "theological inquiry" into the Commonwife designation actually argue? This matters for Ruth.

[DESIGN NOTE: A full-page handwriting workspace after these questions.]

Part IX. Women, marriage and the household order

Since the Restoration Act of 2041, a woman's citizenship has depended on her marital status, and marriage has been a legal and theological designation (TL). The Empire controls women by telling each one what she is and making that classification the frame

of her whole life. It's visible, documented and enforced through paperwork, ceremony and public record (MEN). This part lays out the designations, how a girl gets sorted into one, how the Binding works, and what the household looks like on paper.

IX.1 The designations

The files name these statuses for women.

Designation	What it is	Source
Anointed Wife	The elite tier. Wife of a Covenant man, and the status the Trials produce. It's attached to the marriage, so a widow loses it.	CR, MEN, FR 19
Stewardwife	Wife of the Administrative Class: elevated enough for status, constrained enough to be manageable. Aurelia has "Stewardwife districts."	CR, DOM
Bonded Wife	The tier Delphine's mother entered when she left the Vowed to marry. Probably the wife of a Bonded man (INFERENCE).	TR
Commonwife	A registration status, not a description (FR 1). Wife of a common man. Subject to quotas, the child quota and Temple review.	TL, MEN, FR 1
Vowed	Women in Temple service: assessors, officiants, observers. A woman can leave by marrying.	CR, TR, DOM
Unbound	Unmarried. Celeste has held it her whole life. "Difficult and surveilled."	TL
Ungoverned	Outside the system altogether. Women who chose exile over designation. Criminal since 2062.	TL, DOM

INFERENCE: Older notes describe a six-tier caste system for women. Leaving out Ungoverned, which sits outside the system, there are six designations above: Anointed, Stewardwife, Bonded, Commonwife, Vowed and Unbound.

OPEN QUESTION: Is that the six? If so, what's the official order, and where does Vowed rank?

The Widowed Covenant (CR) covers Anointed widows. Because the designation belongs to the marriage, a widow holds a temporary status for two years that keeps most of her protections. She's expected to remarry within the Anointed class, or she drops to Stewardwife. The senior Anointed Wives run a network so efficient that no widow has ever fallen below Stewardwife.

[DESIGN NOTE: A ladder diagram would show the designations, how a woman moves between them, and where each door locks.]

IX.2 Being sorted: Designation

Every girl is assessed and given an initial classification. In Aurem it happens at eighteen, by a Vowed officer, testing literacy, theological knowledge and "domestic aptitude." The result is a preliminary designation on the Unbound track or the elevated track. The elevated track means better education and a chance at Covenant Daughter consideration (DOM).

The age and method vary by Dominion (DOM).

Dominion	When and how
Aurem	At 18, assessed by a Vowed officer
Gulf	At 14, the Procession, "a declaration of loyalty and readiness for designation"
Ardenne	Standard Designation in Ashford. Hollow children are tested only when they can be brought in.
Meridian	Three-day sessions: theology, written reasoning, policy and "relational compliance"
Vane	At 16, the Broadcast Assessment, partly filmed
Irongate	At 14, the community Placement. At 18, Imperial Designation.
Heartland	At 13, the First Covenant, where her track is publicly set
Red Earth	At 18, two weeks in Temple spaces, Crown facilities and "domestic simulation environments"

Dominion	When and how
Lone	At 16 in Covenant Basin. The First Ride in the outer territories.
Mountain	At 16, with a physical assessment. Girls selected for classified Vowed service disappear from public life.
Sable	At 18 in Sable Reach. The Finding in outer communities.
Pacific	At 18. Every score is reviewed in the Crownward for signs of inherited resistance.

The Regional Assessment for the Covenant Trials is a separate process for women 18 to 25 on a Dominion's Covenant Registry. See Part XI. The placements on the Aurelia board in Draft Three show where an assessed girl can land: Administration, Education, Domestic Service, Housekeeping, Food Service, Binding Recommendation and Remedial Instruction (DR3). Strong doctrine scores can lead to Temple Administration. Strong household judgment can earn a Binding recommendation. Girls who test well everywhere can go on to professional placement (DR3).

IX.3 The Binding

The Binding is marriage as legal and theological designation (TL). In Aurem it's held in a Temple, witnessed by a Vowed officiant, and registered with the Crown and the Temple at the same time. The bride wears white and gold and takes a new surname hyphenated with her husband's. "Nobody asks if she consents. They ask if she is worthy. The correct answer is yes" (DOM). Ministers sign Binding certificates, adding their names beneath each husband's (DR3).

Every Dominion's version differs (DOM).

- **Meridian:** the most legally elaborate, with registration that can take three weeks.
- **Red Earth:** the most surveilled. Vowed officers witness every Binding, because the quota system needs real-time records.
- **Mountain:** Crown officers witness alongside Temple officiants.
- **Sable Reach:** Bindings happen at dawn.
- **Gulf:** keeps its music.

In the Crownward, a Commonwife Binding is a short registration at the Crown office, while an Administrative Class Binding is a dignified ceremony recorded for the Broadcast (CR).

The Imperial Binding for the Crown Heir has seven public stages (CR).

1. The Declaration
2. Covenant Week
3. The Anointing, a private ceremony on the sixth day in which the Prelate anoints the bride
4. The Binding Night
5. The Grand Binding, four hours in the Temple Sanctum
6. The Public Procession down Sovereign Boulevard
7. The Private Supper, five guests at most

The bride's vows are twice as long as the heir's. The Empire calls that theology. In practice it's a legal document spoken aloud in a sacred building (CR).

OPEN QUESTION: Does the hyphenated surname apply only in Aurem, or Empire-wide? Celeste never took a Binding name, so she's still a Parish (AM). Miriam's name after her Binding would be something like Parish-Osei.

IX.4 Commonwife marriage and the quotas

Commonwife marriage is how the Empire marries off the labor class. Aurem has the highest Commonwife rate in the Empire, because the Empire deliberately made marriage look like the highest honor available there (DOM). The quotas were introduced under Crest in 2062 (TL), after a pilot in Red Earth in 2058 (DOM). They're the reason Red Earth Bindings are documented in real time (DOM).

A Commonwife is expected to conceive within the Covenant timeline. In Aurem, a Vowed officer conducts quarterly household assessments in Commonwife homes. Two years without a pregnancy brings informal comments first and then Temple review (MEN, TL). (Volume Two, Leah.)

When a husband abandons his Commonwife, she can be reassigned to another man's household. That's what happened to Miriam after Thomas left (FR 0).

OPEN QUESTION: How does reassignment work? Who decides it, what is the woman's status during it, and why did Solomon keep the Osei name? FR 0 deliberately leaves these open.

IX.5 Anointed Wives and the Arrangement

The first Anointed marriage was Elias Vane's to Sera Callum in 2048. Every Trial since has tried to manufacture it again on camera (TL, AM). All thirty-nine Trials place Anointed wives, and the Crown contest is a layer on top. One woman goes to the heir. The other eleven are married down the elite ladder as designated, and nobody goes home unassigned (FR 19).

The elite husbands are chosen by the oversight committee and ranked by standing, not performance. A man can't reject the woman assigned to him, but he can decline the assignment altogether, which removes him from the ladder. It has happened twice (FR 28).

Among the Anointed Court, the official theology of male headship is mostly performance. The women run what they call the Arrangement. Wives manage the information, relationships and social intelligence that make their husbands' positions work, and they surface the right idea in private so their husbands can present it in public. They never take credit or contradict their husbands publicly. Their compensation is influence, access and the legal protections of the Anointed designation. New Anointed Wives learn it in their first year of marriage (CR). Lyris runs the whole network, which she inherited from the Anointed Wife who mentored her (CR). Celeste told Eden about the Arrangement before she ever left Aurem (CR).

INFERENCE: Ladies in Waiting, the Trial's third- and fourth-place finishers, stay in the Crownward in supporting roles (TR). Under FR 19 they would also be married into elite households. The two rules fit together if Ladies in Waiting are placed in Crownward households and serve the Anointed Wife on top of that.

IX.6 Unbound women and the household on paper

Unbound designation is "difficult and surveilled" (TL). An Unbound woman can head a household only through reclassification, and household paperwork still demands an adult male authority. Celeste's reclassification took six years, and Solomon's vocational form came back to the house until Zion, at eighteen, declared himself the authority (TL, DR3).

The Empire classifies children by household registration, not by parentage or appearance (FR 32). This rule applies Dominion-wide, beyond any one character. Hannah's daughter Naomi is eligible through Hannah's household and standing, whatever her father's status is (FR 31).

Home Instruction is an opportunity a minister can nominate a young woman for. Bell offered to nominate Leah "for Home Instruction the following year" as a consolation (DR3).

OPEN QUESTION: What is Home Instruction? Training for wives, a teaching role, or something else?

The Ungoverned are women who chose exile over designation. Their deepest roots are in the Ardenne hollows, where some communities have lived outside the system for two or three generations. The Empire calls them criminals, and the mountain people call them something closer to saints (DOM). Ungoverned crossings happen through the Sable desert (DOM). Lone interprets "Ungoverned" loosely and never files a full report (DOM). Saint Meridian has the largest population of Ungoverned sympathizers, people embedded in the system who leave gaps in it on purpose (DOM).

IX.7 What the households look like

POSSIBLE: The plainest way to keep the order straight while drafting is to picture the four households the book shows.

- Celeste's is Unbound, reclassified, with a young man on the authority line.
- Leah's is a Commonwife household under quarterly assessment.
- Hannah's is a former Vowed woman's household whose daughter is eligible through her mother.
- The Anointed Court households run on the Arrangement.

Each one is a different answer to the same law.

[DESIGN NOTE: Side-by-side comparison of those four households: who's on the paper, who actually decides, what's assessed, and what's hidden.]

Working questions

1. What are the six tiers officially called, and in what order? Can a woman move up, or only down?
2. What exactly is the Covenant timeline for conception, and what happens after Temple review? Is there a step beyond it?
3. How does Commonwife reassignment work, and who in Aurelia decides it?
4. Does the hyphenated Binding surname apply everywhere, or only in Aurem? What did Miriam's name become?

5. What is Home Instruction?
6. What can an Unbound woman legally own, sign or inherit?
7. What happens to a woman's designation if her husband is convicted of something, or declared Ungoverned?
8. Who are the two men who declined their elite assignments (FR 28), and what happened to them?
9. What do the senior Anointed Wives do for a Widowed Covenant woman in those two years?
10. What does an Aurem bride actually say when she's asked if she's worthy?
11. How does a girl in the Ardenne hollows end up Ungoverned instead of designated, and does anyone ever go back?

[DESIGN NOTE: A full-page handwriting workspace after these questions.]

Part X. The Twelve Dominions

The Dominion Act of 2044 reorganized the states into twelve Dominions by region and economic function. The borders roughly follow the old state lines but not exactly, since some states were absorbed and some were split (TL). Each Dominion has a seat city renamed from an American city, its own Governor-Prelate, and a culture that's sometimes Imperial on the surface and sometimes all the way through. The rites of passage are collected in Part VIII.4. This part gives each Dominion's history, landscape, culture and record in the Trials.

Dominion	Seat (formerly)	Territory	In the Trials
Aurem	Aurelia (Atlanta)	Georgia, Alabama, Mississippi, Tennessee, South Carolina, North Carolina	15 Anointed Wives in 38 Trials, the most of any Dominion
Gulf	Port Seraphine (New Orleans)	Louisiana, the Mississippi Gulf Coast, Florida	Historically penalized for warmth
Ardenne	Ashford (Charleston, WV)	West Virginia, Virginia, Kentucky, Appalachia	Rarely produces Covenant Daughters
Meridian	Blessed Shore (Philadelphia)	Pennsylvania, Maryland, New Jersey, Delaware	Extremely prepared candidates

Dominion	Seat (formerly)	Territory	In the Trials
Vane	Saint Meridian (New York City)	New York and New England	The legacy Dominion, with the most Anointed Wives after Aurem
Irongate	Iron Benediction (Chicago)	Illinois, Indiana, Ohio, Michigan, Wisconsin	Almost always administrative daughters
Heartland	Providence Cross (Kansas City)	Missouri, Kansas, Iowa, Nebraska, Minnesota, the Dakotas	The most theologically fluent
Red Earth	Canaan's Gate (Oklahoma City)	Oklahoma, Arkansas, eastern Kansas, southwestern Missouri	Often scored mid-pack until it's too late
Lone	Covenant Basin (Houston)	Texas, New Mexico, western Louisiana	Pragmatic about the outcome
Mountain	Crestfall (Denver)	Colorado, Wyoming, Montana, Idaho, parts of Utah and Nevada	Has never produced an Anointed Wife
Sable	Sable Reach (Phoenix)	Arizona, Nevada, New Mexico, parts of Utah	"Two Sable women are worth five from anywhere else"
Pacific	Westhold (Los Angeles)	California, Oregon, parts of Nevada	Watched before they arrive

Source for the table and everything in this part: DOM, unless tagged otherwise.

INFERENCE: The overlaps (Mississippi, Kansas, Missouri, Louisiana, New Mexico, Nevada and Utah each show up in two Dominions) fit the timeline's "some states split."

OPEN QUESTION: Washington, Alaska and Hawaii don't appear in any Dominion. Are they inside Pacific, outside the Empire, or something else?

[DESIGN NOTE: Map needed here: the Twelve Dominions over the old state lines, with the seat cities and the Crownward marked.]

X.1 Aurem

Atlanta had Black wealth, Black culture, Black education and Black memory built so deep into the city that the Coalition couldn't flatten it without admitting what it was erasing. So the Empire dressed it up and called it restoration. The BeltLine became a ceremonial promenade lined with statues and Broadcast screens. Historic neighborhoods became Stewardwife districts, and Peachtree Street became Covenant Way. Magnolias were planted everywhere because they photograph well and rot slowly. Aurelia is the Empire's favorite mirror, Atlanta wearing somebody else's clothes, and the most surveilled and showcased territory in the Empire (TL).

It's humid from May through October. Storms leave the streets smelling of pine and wet concrete, and the red clay keeps bleeding through the paving. Black culture went deepest underground here and survived most stubbornly. Imperial hymns play on Covenant Way, and something else plays in the outer districts. Food is the main vessel of memory, and the Empire never thought the kitchen was dangerous enough to watch.

Aurem has the highest Commonwife rate and the most elaborate marriage ceremonies in the Empire, on purpose. It's the Empire's favorite Broadcast Dominion, with fifteen Anointed Wives across thirty-eight Trials. Its Covenant Daughter gets forty-seven seconds on Sovereign Boulevard in the Opening Procession, more than anyone else, and every girl in Aurem knows that number before she can read. An Aurem candidate is expected to win. The outer districts watch the scores with the intensity of people who never see their names on anything. Death is the place where "the Empire lost completely and still has no idea" (see VIII.4).

X.2 Gulf

New Orleans was never going to be easy. The first Governor-Prelate lasted fourteen months and reported the city "resistant to spiritual reorientation." The Empire settled for managing it. Port Seraphine is loyal enough for the Broadcast and layered enough underground that the Vowed have learned to look away. Hurricane season takes half the year, and the city is "built on water and spite." Gulf is the most culturally intact Dominion: music survived here, standing in plain sight, because tourism, rebranded as "cultural pilgrimage," earns too much to lose. Gulf candidates arrive fluent in being watched, and the scoring system has historically penalized them for warmth, which Crown advisors read as performance. A Gulf woman who knows the gap between what she shows and what she keeps is one of the most dangerous women in the room.

X.3 Ardenne

Appalachia was never fully inside America's idea of itself, and it isn't fully inside the Empire's. Ashford is the city the Empire keeps as proof that Ardenne is pacified, and everything past the tree line says otherwise. It has real winters, hollows that cut communities off from each other and from surveillance, and fog thick enough to hide the next house. The Ungoverned have their deepest roots here. Outer Ardenne children who get assessed score extraordinarily well, since children raised to solve real problems do well on problem-solving tests. Ardenne rarely sends a Covenant Daughter, and when it does she's usually from Ashford and quiet about the gap.

X.4 Meridian

The Empire took Philadelphia for its symbolism. The city that held the Declaration of Independence now holds the legal architecture of everything the Declaration claimed to prevent. Blessed Shore houses the Covenant Court's secondary chambers. Meridian absorbed Imperial culture more completely than almost anywhere, because its administrators trust process. Its underground is made of lawyers and bureaucrats filing precise challenges that go nowhere and documenting them for a future someone is preparing. Stewardwives here are expert readers of Binding contracts, trained in Reading Circles. Meridian candidates know every rule and where the gaps are, which makes one who decides to move almost impossible to stop. Corinne Vale is from Blessed Shore (TR).

X.5 Vane

New York was the hardest cultural conquest and the one the Empire brags about most. It named the whole Dominion after its founding Emperor, which is both honor and leash. Saint Meridian is the Broadcast capital, and the studios that announce Trial scores sit in old Midtown. The skyline stayed, and everything underneath it changed. The city's density makes surveillance both total and porous, and it has the largest Ungoverned-sympathizer population of any seat city. Vane is the legacy Dominion. Some families have sent Covenant Daughters to three consecutive Trials, and high-scoring girls are prepared for candidacy from the time they can read. Calla Merritt is from Saint Meridian (TR).

X.6 Irongate

Chicago gave the Empire industry and political machinery, which it kept, and music, which it tried to dismantle. Blues and jazz were labeled "morally ambiguous musical forms" in 2053 and went underground. Iron Benediction is the manufacturing heart of the Empire. Irongate is the most class-divided Dominion, and its labor and administrative districts

might as well be different civilizations. The labor-district women run a mutual aid network called the Kitchen that the Vowed have never mapped. Covenant Daughters are almost always administrative daughters, because selection rewards polish and polish costs money. Nadia Orin is the exception, the most working-class Covenant Daughter in Trial history (TR).

X.7 Heartland

The Heartland didn't need conquering, because the Coalition had been building here for decades. Providence Cross is the most genuinely loyal seat city in the Empire. People sing the hymns because they mean them. That sincerity is the Empire's most valuable asset and one of its hardest to control, because real believers have opinions about what faithfulness requires. Some of the Empire's most serious theological debates happen here, including Heartland women's "theological inquiry" into the Commonwife designation. Heartland sends the most theologically fluent Covenant Daughters, for whom devotion is both credential and liability. Ruth Gideon is from Providence Cross (TR).

X.8 Red Earth

Oklahoma's history of land taken and people removed came before the Empire. Canaan's Gate is built over a city that survived the 1995 bombing, and the Empire likes that resilience story. Red Earth piloted the Commonwife quota in 2058, and its women have lived under the full version longest. It's the most visibly religious Dominion in its architecture and the most privately exhausted, with scripture on every building and the Vowed embedded as "pastoral care." Under the performance runs a language of small signals refined over decades. Red Earth candidates are the best in the Empire at performing compliance while thinking something else. Delia Cross is from Canaan's Gate. Her family was transferred there from Aurem when she was six, and she carries a grudge against the Dominion she left (TR).

X.9 Lone

Texas negotiated its surrender. The Empire got the territory and Texas kept the attitude. Covenant Basin runs on oil wealth and space infrastructure. Its Governor-Prelate is always Texas-born and has more independence than any other. The distances leave real gaps in the surveillance grid, so west Lone is managed through local Vowed officers. People here perform loyalty loudly and then do what they were going to do anyway, and outer-territory women have a practical autonomy that would get them flagged in Aurem. Lone treats the Trials like any other Imperial requirement. Vivienne Hale is from Covenant Basin (TR).

X.10 Mountain

The Empire wanted the mountains for what's inside them: minerals, military installations, elevation and secrecy. Crestfall is the face, and the mountains are the truth. The classified operations there are the Empire's least documented and most important work: surveillance technology, resource extraction, Temple expansion funding and military capacity. Crestfall women are the most physically capable in the Empire and among the most watched. Girls selected at Designation for classified Vowed service disappear from public life. Mountain has never produced an Anointed Wife. Endurance was held in Mountain terrain for Trials 1 through 31, moved to a controlled facility for 32 through 38, and returned to the mountains for the 39th without explanation. Petra Solano is from Crestfall (TR). Azrael is hidden in Mountain Dominion, in a community whose patriarch owes the Vanes a debt (TL). Lyris is from Mountain too (WR).

X.11 Sable

The desert resists the Empire the way deserts resist everything, by not caring. Heat destroys equipment, sand gets into everything, and the distances defeat centralized monitoring. Sable Reach is the ornate Imperial city the Empire keeps as proof it can reach hard country. The desert beyond it is where Ungoverned crossings happen. The desert held civilizations long before the United States, and the Empire renamed the cities but not the land. Women in the outer communities carry plant and land knowledge the Empire has never catalogued. Every Sable woman has two names, one for the Empire and one for the house. Zara Voss is from Sable Reach, and her desert name is Tazaleh (TL, TR).

INTERPRETATION: Sable's two-name custom and Celeste's house name for Eden are the same instinct in two Dominions. Eden and Zara's name exchange in the middle of the book rests on it.

X.12 Pacific

Pacific carries the memory of resistance like scar tissue. The secession attempt and the two-year standoff produced a generation that remembers trying to leave, and their grandchildren know the story. The Empire watches Westhold harder than anywhere: more cameras per block, more loyalty programming, and a Governor-Prelate Dorian appointed personally, who performs warmth while administering iron. Old Los Angeles's creative industries adapted instead of dying, and people still make what they actually want and pass it through networks the Empire can't map. Every Pacific girl's Designation is reviewed in the Crownward for inherited resistance, and every Pacific Covenant Daughter arrives already flagged. Sera Montoya is from Westhold (TR).

Working questions

1. Where are Washington, Alaska and Hawaii?
2. How did Aurem get fifteen Anointed Wives? Which Trials were they, and does Aurelia remember their names?
3. What does the forty-seven seconds actually show, every year?
4. What is the real name of Aurelia's outer districts, and what do people in Sector Seven call their own streets?
5. What happened in the Gulf the year the Empire tried and failed to stop the music?
6. Who leads the Ungoverned in the Ardenne hollows, and what do they know about the Crownward?
7. What debt does the Mountain patriarch owe the Vanes, and from when?
8. What does each Dominion's Governor-Prelate want from the 39th Trial?
9. Which Dominion would Eden most fear being sent to, and why?
10. What do people in the other eleven Dominions think of Aurem, its forty-seven seconds and its fifteen Anointed Wives?

[DESIGN NOTE: A full-page handwriting workspace after these questions. Each Dominion profile could also get its own half-page of margin space.]

Part XI. The Covenant Trials as an institution

The Covenant Trials are a televised selection. Each Dominion sends one Covenant Daughter, and over about four months the Crown Heir's Anointed Wife is chosen from the twelve. The other eleven are married down the elite ladder (TR, FR 19, 26). The Empire presents the Trials as revelation, not competition, because "a competition can be rigged. A revelation cannot" (TR). This part covers how the Trials work in any year. What happens in the 39th Trial belongs to Volume Two.

XI.1 History

When	What	Source
2048	Elias Vane marries Sera Callum. The first Anointed marriage becomes the template.	TL

When	What	Source
2065	Crest introduces the Trials as "a celebration of the Empire's finest women." The first cycle is rough, and the ratings are extraordinary.	TL
22nd Trial	Ladies in Waiting introduced, to keep high performers in the Crownward instead of sending them home with influence nobody can manage	TR
Trials 1–31	Endurance held in Mountain terrain	DOM
2085	That year's Trial cancelled after Crest dies mid-cycle and Dorian's accession forces an Imperial transition. The twelve are sent home with their designations intact and no placements.	FR 34, 39
From 2085	Under Dorian the Trials become the most-watched event in the Empire's calendar	TL
Trials 32–38	Endurance moved to a controlled facility with continuous filming	TR, DOM
2104	The 39th Trial. Endurance returns to Mountain terrain without public explanation.	TR

INFERENCE: The Trials run every year. The first was in 2065, and with 2085 skipped, the 39th lands in 2104 (FR 39).

The 2085 cohort met while being assembled, prepared and measured against each other, and they're now scattered through their home Dominions. That shared history makes a network possible, but it doesn't activate before Book Two (FR 34). The 2085 cohort is the thing Hannah has never said out loud (FR 30). INFERENCE: She was one of the twelve. (Volume Two, Hannah.)

XI.2 Eligibility and nomination

Every Dominion keeps a Covenant Registry of women aged 18 to 25 who meet five requirements (TR).

- Unbound or elevated designation
- No prior marriage registration
- No Ungoverned citations

- Completion of the standard Imperial curriculum
- "Demonstrated covenantal aptitude," which means whatever the Governor-Prelate needs it to mean

Vowed officers, family members or community leaders can nominate a woman, or she can nominate herself. The Empire frames self-nomination as exceptional faith. In practice the process is built to exhaust anyone without institutional support, and most self-nominations fail for that reason alone (TR). In Aurem, self-nomination is "independent submission": a ten-dollar nonrefundable fee and a registration card printed in red instead of bordered in gold (DR3). Eden is the first Aurem candidate in the Trials' history to enter that way (TL).

Eligibility isn't entry. A House Mother can submit a name, but she isn't the only person who can (FR 27).

XI.3 The Regional Assessment and selection

Each Dominion runs a three-day Regional Assessment under senior Vowed officers, which produces a ranked list (TR, TL). In Aurem, results are posted in the Temple atrium on the third Monday of June at seven in the morning, and the top five are appointed to the Covenant. Their photographs hang in the atrium through the summer, and their families get the useful kind of formal review, the kind where unpaid levies disappear (DR3). Some sections, like Discernment and Spiritual Fitness, are graded by ministerial review, so a girl can know every answer and still fail for a lack of humility (DR3).

The Governor-Prelate chooses the Covenant Daughter from the top three. In practice he picks whoever the Crown has quietly signaled it prefers, then documents it as a choice from the top three regardless of the real ranking (TR).

XI.4 Arrival

The twelve arrive in the first week of summer, staggered across seven days so each arrival can be released as its own day of content. Each travels by Dominion transport with two Appointed Officers and her House Mother (TR). Each walks Sovereign Boulevard on camera. The walk is choreographed, and candidates are told what pace to keep, where to look and how to hold their hands (CR).

XI.5 The Covenant Houses

Twelve townhouses line Covenant Row, one per Dominion, close enough to walk to Sovereign Boulevard in under five minutes. Cameras cover every common area, entrance and garden, but not the bedrooms (CR). The candidates aren't sequestered. They're embedded in Crownward public life: Temple services, forums, the approved dining rooms, the Administrative Side markets (CR).

Each House has permanent staff. In House Aurem those are the House Mother, the House Coordinator, the stylist and the Debate and Protocol Advisor (TL). A House hosts one Covenant Daughter per Trial, and House staff serve across many Trials. Hannah's "six Trials, twelve girls" counts her whole career across several Houses and posts (FR 26).

XI.6 The three phases

The Trials run in three phases. Each belongs to a different power and asks a different question. The three phases also line up with the novel's Genesis, Exodus and Revelation (TR).

Phase	Domain	The question	Components	Weight
One: the Covenant Examination (weeks 1–4)	The Temple (Genesis)	Who are you?	The Settling, the Doctrinal Assessment, the Theological Interview, the Public Testimony	30%
Two: the Governance Trials (weeks 5–10)	The Crown (Exodus)	How smart are you?	The Dominion Forum, the Civic Debates, the Anointed Evening, the Pairing Introduction	30%

Phase	Domain	The question	Components	Weight
Three: Endurance (three days)	The terrain (Revelation)	What are you willing to endure?	Coordinates to reach across three days, with no schedule, no handlers and no cameras after deployment	Feeds the Broadcast's 40%

Phase One. The Settling is presented as a grace period, and it's actually the most intensive assessment of all, because the Vowed watch everything. The Doctrinal Assessment is a six-hour written exam in the Temple Sanctum, set at each candidate's ceiling, so no two girls get the same questions. The Theological Interview is a conversation with a senior Vowed officer, who's told to pursue any rehearsed answer until she finds what's underneath it. The Public Testimony is a fifteen-minute statement of faith and purpose, broadcast live, and the first time the Empire hears each candidate speak unmediated. Candidates are given Vowed handlers to "ensure theological accuracy," and they can decline them (TR).

Phase Two. The Dominion Forum puts every remaining candidate in a room with an Empire-wide crisis and no assigned leader. The Civic Debates are three filmed debates on governance, theology and social policy, with the topics given an hour beforehand, and the Crown Heir moderates the social policy debate. The Anointed Evening is four hours with the Anointed Court in the Crown Palace, where the cameras can't follow into the side rooms. The Pairing Introduction is thirty minutes alone with the Heir, with a Crown advisor and a Vowed officer present and a camera outside the door. The room itself isn't recorded (TR). The Commission has been known to wire candidates before Pairing Introductions (TR).

Phase Three. Endurance tests what the Empire calls covenantal fortitude and the terrain calls survival. The Broadcast films the deployment and the final checkpoint. Everything in between is reconstructed afterward from the candidates' accounts and is always incomplete (TR).

SUPERSEDED: The original Trials file used four phases: the Covenant Examination, the Governance Trials, the Public Season and the Declaration.

OPEN QUESTION: The original file also had candidates sign a confidentiality covenant before the Crown's phase, with immediate removal and a permanent Ungoverned citation for breaking it (TR-orig). Does that rule still exist?

XI.7 Scoring

The Covenant Score is a composite. The weights are never disclosed: Temple 30 percent, Crown 30 percent, Broadcast 40 percent. The Broadcast's share includes narrative-priority decisions by the Broadcast Director (TR). Scores update on the Sovereign Boulevard screens every evening at seven, in a ritual the Empire named the Evening Reckoning (TR).

Every Trial produces a Broadcast antagonist narrative, and it's assigned to the candidate who most threatens a comfortable outcome, not to the eventual winner. When a candidate's intelligence becomes the story instead of her compliance, the Broadcast calls it internally the Eve problem. The narrative implies and never accuses. It moves the Covenant Score without changing a single formal assessment, and it has worked every time it's been used (TR).

XI.8 The Declaration and its rules

After the Endurance rankings are confirmed, the Crown Heir names his Anointed Wife in a public ceremony on Sovereign Boulevard, broadcast live in all twelve Dominions (TR). The rules around that moment come from your Final Rulings.

- **The ranked winner.** The heir may choose any of the twelve. "Without deviation" describes the record, not a rule (FR 20).
- **What winning means.** Being the choice that costs the Crown nothing. The rankings tell the heir which selection is free. Deviation is permitted and expensive, and no heir has ever paid it (FR 21).
- **Refusal.** The recommendation stands by default once the Declaration window closes. Refusing is abstention, not resistance, and produces the same result as complying (FR 22).
- **Cancellation.** Impossible once the Trial is announced, except in a public dynastic emergency: the Heir's death or incapacity, or the Emperor's death forcing an immediate transition. A candidate's death doesn't downgrade a Trial (FR 23).
- **A candidate's death.** Her status goes back to her family, with no compensation and no punishment, as though the designation had never been made (FR 24).

- **Rejected candidates.** Married down as designated. The rejection follows them "not in the record, in the room" (FR 25).
- **Ladies in Waiting.** The third- and fourth-place Endurance finishers stay in the Crownward in supporting roles to the Anointed Wife and the Crown household (TR).

The Imperial Binding that follows is covered in Part IX.3.

XI.9 The Covenant Daughters of the 39th Trial

For reference. Their stories are in Volume Two, Part III.

Covenant Daughter	Dominion	From	Age
Eden Selah Osei	Aurem	Aurelia	21
Delphine Fontenot	Gulf	Port Seraphine	22
Maren Cole	Ardenne	Ashford	23
Corinne Vale	Meridian	Blessed Shore	22
Calla Merritt	Vane	Saint Meridian	21
Nadia Orin	Irongate	Iron Benediction	20
Ruth Gideon	Heartland	Providence Cross	22
Delia Cross	Red Earth	Canaan's Gate	24
Vivienne Hale	Lone	Covenant Basin	23
Petra Solano	Mountain	Crestfall	22
Zara Voss	Sable	Sable Reach	21
Sera Montoya	Pacific	Westhold	24

Source: TR, Ruling (Calla's surname).

Working questions

1. Who sits on the Trials Commission and the oversight committee, and are they the same body?
2. What do Ladies in Waiting actually do day to day, and who has held the title?
3. What were the Trials like in the 2060s and 2070s, before Dorian made them spectacle?

4. Who chose to bring Endurance back to Mountain terrain for the 39th, and why?
5. What does a Doctrinal Assessment question look like at Eden's ceiling? Write one.
6. What does a House Mother do across a career of many Trials? What happens to House staff when their girl loses?
7. What has happened to the women the Eve narrative was used on in earlier Trials?
8. Has a Covenant Daughter ever died before Petra? How did the Empire handle it?
9. What does the Broadcast's narrative-priority decision look like inside the Citadel, and who signs off on it?
10. What does a girl's family in Aurem get, specifically, when she's appointed to the Covenant?
11. What do the men assigned to the eleven know about their brides before the Declaration?
12. Does the confidentiality covenant still exist?

[DESIGN NOTE: The phase table could become a two-page structural diagram: three phases across, components beneath each, weights along the bottom, and the novel's three parts above.]

[DESIGN NOTE: A full-page handwriting workspace after these questions.]

The scripture parts: how Parts I–V work

Parts I through V cover the book the Empire inherited: what the Bible is, how it's read, the books themselves, the people in them, and how states have used it. When the volume is assembled they go ahead of the world parts. They're rebuilt from the old Companion's research, rewritten in the new voice, with every claim checked again. A spot check turned up real errors in the old version, so nothing was carried over on trust.

One convention is different here. Most of this material is outside research, and a RESEARCH label on every paragraph would bury the page, so in Parts I–V unlabeled prose is RESEARCH. TKC material carries its source tag as usual. CONTESTED, INTERPRETATION, POSSIBLE and the other labels still mark everything that isn't settled fact. Scholars are named in the text where a position belongs to them. Each part ends with a short "For TKC" section that connects the research to the world parts, and with working questions.

The standard references behind this material are the ones in the old Companion's Sources and Editions pages: Biblia Hebraica Stuttgartensia, Rahlfs–Hanhart, NA28 and UBS5 for the texts; BDB and HALOT for Hebrew; the Anchor commentaries (Milgrom on Leviticus, Weinfeld on Deuteronomy); and Sanders and Ehrman on the New Testament. Page-level references are still an open proofing task, as they were in the old version.

Part I. Scripture as a library

The Bible is a library, not a single book. It's a collection of documents written over roughly a thousand years in three languages, by many hands, for audiences who mostly didn't know the other documents existed. Its writers sometimes disagree with one another, and the collection keeps both sides. To write a world in which an empire quotes this book, you need to know what's in it, how it came together, what kinds of writing it holds, and where its readers have always divided.

I.1 What the Bible is

The sixty-six-book Protestant Bible has thirty-nine books in the Old Testament and twenty-seven in the New. It's written in Hebrew, some Aramaic (parts of Daniel and Ezra) and Greek. No single author or editor produced it, and it never had an original title page.

Other traditions draw the edges differently, and the order of the books is itself an argument about what the story is.

Collection	Books	How it's arranged	Where it ends
Tanakh (Jewish)	24	Torah, Prophets (Nevi'im), Writings (Ketuvim). A complete scripture, not an "Old Testament."	Chronicles, with Cyrus's decree to go up and rebuild. The story closes on return.
Protestant	66	39 Old Testament books (the same Hebrew books as the Tanakh, counted and ordered differently) and 27 New Testament books	Malachi, then Revelation. The Hebrew scriptures end on a promise, which frames them as prologue.

Collection	Books	How it's arranged	Where it ends
Catholic	73	Adds the deuterocanonical books: Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Sirach, Baruch, 1–2 Maccabees, and additions to Esther and Daniel	Includes the Maccabean revolt, armed resistance to an empire that outlawed the faith
Orthodox	76 or more	Varies by communion. The Greek, Slavonic and Ethiopian traditions differ from each other. The Ethiopian canon is the largest.	No single answer. Canon has never been uniform worldwide.

The old Companion had a typo here ("28 New"). The Protestant New Testament has twenty-seven books.

The Bible also doesn't speak in one voice. It holds conversations its own writers never resolved.

The tension	What's actually in dispute
Deuteronomy and Job	Deuteronomy ties covenant faithfulness to flourishing. Job gives a righteous man catastrophe and lets his friends make the simple version of that argument until it fails. The dispute is over retributive theology used as a rule.
Ezra and Ruth	Ezra–Nehemiah records foreign marriages being dissolved as restoration policy. Ruth makes a Moabite woman David's great-grandmother. Each gives a different answer to the same question about who belongs.
Proverbs and Ecclesiastes	Proverbs teaches that wisdom can be learned and generally pays. Ecclesiastes looks at the same world and reports that the pattern doesn't hold.
Court and prophet	The court histories tell kingship from inside the palace. The prophets address the same kings from outside, about the poor, the widow, the foreigner and the worker, and also about idolatry, false worship and foreign alliances.

INTERPRETATION: These read best as tensions inside one tradition, not as authors calling each other liars. The old overview page's line that "Job says that is a lie told by comfortable men" overstated it, and the old Companion corrected it a few pages later.

I.2 How the canon was assembled

No single meeting ever decided the Bible. Communities read, copied and prayed with these texts for generations before anyone published a list, and the lists mostly ratified habits that were already in place. A congregation in Alexandria and one in Carthage could disagree about a book for a century without either one considering itself in schism.

The Hebrew scriptures settled in three stages. The Torah worked as authoritative law for the restored Judean community by the Persian period, around the fifth century BCE. Nehemiah 8 shows it being read in public. The Prophets were recognized as a body later. By the second century BCE, writers could refer to "the law and the prophets" as a known pair. The Writings settled last. Psalms and Proverbs were uncontroversial, and Esther, Ecclesiastes and Song of Songs were still being discussed in the rabbinic period.

The Septuagint, the Greek translation made for Greek-speaking Jews starting in Alexandria in the third century BCE, held a wider and looser collection. Most New Testament writers quote it, which is why the Christian Old Testament inherited a different shape.

The Dead Sea Scrolls, found between 1947 and 1956, include biblical manuscripts about a thousand years older than the standard medieval Hebrew codices. They show a text that's remarkably stable in most places and genuinely variable in others. That corrects both the idea that the Hebrew Bible never changed and the idea that it was rewritten wholesale.

The New Testament came together over about three centuries.

When	What happened
c. 50–60 CE	Paul's letters, the earliest New Testament documents, written before any Gospel
c. 70–100 CE	The Gospels, written after the Temple's destruction in 70
Mid-2nd century	Marcion publishes a deliberately reduced collection: an edited Luke and ten of Paul's letters. The reaction sharpens everyone's sense that the boundary matters.
c. 180	Irenaeus argues for exactly four Gospels. Arguing for the number shows it was contested enough to need defending.
Date disputed	The Muratorian fragment lists much of what becomes the New Testament and leaves some of it out. Most scholars date it to the late second century, and a minority place it in the fourth. CONTESTED
Early 4th century	Eusebius sorts books into accepted, disputed and rejected. It's a working scholar's triage, not a ruling.
367	Athanasius's Easter letter lists the twenty-seven books of today's New Testament
393 and 397	Regional councils at Hippo and Carthage in North Africa affirm lists close to today's

When	What happened
c. 382–405	Jerome produces the Latin Vulgate and flags the books he considers secondary, a distinction Rome didn't adopt
1546	The Council of Trent affirms the deuterocanonical books for Catholics. Protestant reformers had moved them to a separate section or dropped them.

Emperors did fund copies and convene meetings. Constantine's role at Nicaea in 325 was real, but Nicaea wasn't about the canon. INTERPRETATION: The defensible claim is that the people who could convene, fund, copy and distribute had outsized influence over which texts stayed in circulation, and circulation is most of what canon means in practice.

Some books took longer to be accepted than others, and each had its own recorded objection.

Book	The objection
Esther	The Hebrew text never names God, and its festival, Purim, isn't in the Torah. The Greek version adds explicitly religious material.
Song of Songs	Explicit love poetry with no overt theology. Reading it as an allegory of God and Israel, or Christ and the church, became the standard defense.
Ecclesiastes	Its conclusions sit awkwardly beside the rest of wisdom literature. Many scholars read its closing verses as a later frame.
Hebrews	Anonymous. The West accepted it more slowly because Pauline authorship couldn't be shown, and nearly all scholars now agree Paul didn't write it.
James	Slow to circulate. Later Luther ranked it, along with Hebrews, Jude and Revelation, below the rest and placed it at the back of his 1522 New Testament.
2 Peter	The most doubted New Testament book in antiquity, on grounds of style and attribution

Book	The objection
Jude	Quotes 1 Enoch, a book outside the canon it ended up in
Revelation	Long resisted in the Greek East. It's accepted as scripture by the Eastern Orthodox churches and still isn't read aloud in their liturgy.

Revelation's place in Orthodox worship shows that a book can be fully canonical and still never be read aloud.

I.3 Genres

Genre determines what a passage is capable of establishing, and misreading it is the most common way a sincere reader reaches a confident wrong answer.

Genre	What it's trying to do	What it can't establish
Law	Set a community's obligations, ritual, civil and moral, usually without separating them	Timeless policy for every society
Narrative	Tell what happened, shaped for a purpose. It often reports behavior without endorsing it.	Approval. A story about polygamy isn't an argument for it.
Poetry	Make something felt through image and parallel lines	Doctrine built on a metaphor read literally
Wisdom	Teach how the world generally works, and (in Job and Ecclesiastes) how often it doesn't	Promises. A proverb is a pattern, not a guarantee.
Prophecy	Deliver a message to a particular people at a particular moment: indictment, warning, consolation, sometimes prediction	A calendar. Most prophecy addresses its own audience's present, though later readers often read it forward.
Gospel	Present a life so the reader has to reckon with it. Ancient biography with a purpose.	A transcript. Selection and arrangement are part of the form.

Genre	What it's trying to do	What it can't establish
Letter	Address a live situation in a named community, often with sustained theological argument	Rules without context. You're reading one side of a conversation.
Apocalyptic	Reveal what's really happening behind visible power, in symbols, for people who can't say it plainly	Forecasts of technology. Its symbols were legible to its first readers.

Inside these genres are smaller forms. A genealogy is a claim about belonging, and Matthew's list deliberately includes four women. A lament is structured complaint, often addressed to God and often unresolved, and its place in the canon makes protest a sanctioned form of prayer. A parable usually turns on one hinge, and allegorizing every detail is how it gets defused. A court history is a record written near power, so ask who commissioned it and what it leaves out.

Before a character quotes anything at anyone, ask what kind of writing it is, who it was addressed to, and what the speaker gains by treating it as a rule.

I.4 Translation

No original manuscript of any biblical book survives. What exists is thousands of copies, and they differ, overwhelmingly in spelling, word order and obvious copying slips, and occasionally in something substantive. Textual criticism reconstructs the earliest recoverable text from that evidence. A few famous passages are missing from the earliest manuscripts, and reputable Bibles say so in a footnote: the longer ending of Mark (16:9–20), the woman caught in adultery (John 7:53–8:11), and the Trinitarian clause in 1 John 5:7–8.

Hebrew was originally written without vowels. The vowel points were added centuries later by the Masoretes, scribes preserving how the text was read aloud, so a consonantal text can sometimes be vocalized more than one way. The New Testament is in Koine, the common Greek of the eastern Mediterranean. It isn't uniform: Mark's Greek is rough, and Hebrews' is polished.

Translations sit on a spectrum, and every point on it gives something up.

Approach	Examples	What it prioritizes	What it gives up
Formal ("literal")	KJV, NASB, ESV	The original's structure and ambiguity	Clarity in places. An ambiguity preserved is still one you have to resolve.
Middle	NIV, NRSV, CSB	Accuracy in natural English	Some seams
Functional ("dynamic")	NLT, Good News	What the sentence does, in idiomatic English	The translator has already chosen for you where the original was ambiguous
Paraphrase	The Message	Immediate impact	Any claim to precision

Most differences between translations aren't ideological. They come from a genuinely ambiguous word, a construction with no clean English equivalent, a choice about register, or a choice between manuscripts. Some differences are theologically motivated, and those are worth finding, but if you assume every difference is, you won't be able to spot the real ones.

The King James Version matters most for TKC. It was commissioned by James I in 1604, completed in 1611 by about fifty scholars working in six companies, and based heavily on the earlier Bishops' Bible. Its rules allowed no marginal notes except brief explanations of Hebrew or Greek words. That rule was a direct response to the Geneva Bible, the Puritans' Bible, whose notes James considered seditious. One Geneva note praised the Hebrew midwives for disobeying Pharaoh (Exodus 1:19). Another faulted King Asa for only deposing his idolatrous mother instead of executing her (2 Chronicles 15:16). INTERPRETATION: The Bible most English-speaking Protestants grew up with was shaped, in part, by a king who wanted the commentary on obeying kings taken out.

Chapters, verses and headings aren't scripture. Chapter divisions date to the early thirteenth century and are usually credited to Stephen Langton. Numbered New Testament verses first appeared in Robert Estienne's Greek New Testament of 1551. Jewish scribes had already marked verse divisions in the Hebrew text, though not numbered in the modern way. Section headings are modern editorial additions. Divisions make the text findable and quotable, and they also impose breaks the author didn't write.

There are four times when comparing English Bibles isn't enough and you need a lexicon, a commentary or a scholar:

- the argument rests on a single word
- translations split along denominational lines
- a footnote says the text is uncertain
- you're about to say what the original "really" means

I.5 Reading a passage in context

There are eight questions, and they should be asked in order. Most confident misuse of scripture comes from skipping one.

1. **What kind of text is this?** Genre first. It decides what the passage can establish.
2. **Who's speaking?** The narrator, a character, God as quoted, or a friend who turns out to be wrong. Job's comforters are in the Bible, and the book says they're mistaken.
3. **To whom?** A congregation with a particular problem, a king, a foreign nation, or one person.
4. **What comes before and after?** Read the paragraph, then the chapter. Most weaponized verses only work once the sentences on either side have been cut.
5. **What world produced it?** Empire, exile, monarchy, the household economy, and the legal status of women and slaves. The setting is often the subject.
6. **What do the words do?** Command, describe, lament, promise, threaten, concede or argue. Check two translations to see whether they agree.
7. **Who gains from this reading?** Ask it of every reading, including the one you prefer.
8. **What does this reading cost, and who pays?**

The method can't make anyone an authority. What it does is let you tell a reading that has done the work from one that skipped a step, and say which step was skipped.

I.6 Contested readings

Not all disagreement is the same kind, and the most important skill in this part is telling them apart.

1. **Serious scholarly dispute.** Specialists who know the languages and the manuscripts disagree, and each side can state the other's evidence. Examples are the meaning of *kephalē* and the authorship of Ephesians. In a scene, this earns two credible characters.
2. **Denominational disagreement.** Communities differ because of their confessions, their governance and inherited practice, not because the evidence is contested. Examples are who may be ordained and whether Revelation is read aloud.

3. **Open theological questions.** These are questions the text raises and leaves open, like what the conquest narratives say about God or whether Job is ever answered. They're where a novel does its best work.
4. **Unsupported claims.** Invented etymologies, a word supposedly mistranslated in every Bible, a council that decided something it never discussed. These aren't contested. They're wrong, though a character can sincerely believe one and build a life on it.

Eight fault lines run through the book. Each is a place where readers divide, and each is somewhere the Empire has a doctrine.

Fault line	What's actually in dispute	Where TKC touches it
Headship	The range of one Greek noun, how far the mutual-submission verse reaches, and what carries over from a Roman household code	The Binding and the household authority line (Part IX)
Women speaking	Restriction passages in the Pauline letters set against the undisputed letters, which name women as coworkers, a deacon (Phoebe) and an apostle (Junia, Romans 16:7). Authorship and dating matter here.	The Vowed, and who may teach versus only recite
Slavery	Texts that regulate slavery without abolishing it, and the principle a tradition later used to call it wrong	Labor tracks and designation
Divine violence	Whether the conquest narratives are history, theological rhetoric, later reflection or ancient war convention	Every Imperial purge described as cleansing
Obedience to rulers	Romans 13 set against the prophets, Revelation and the movement's own martyrs	The Empire's legitimacy
Wealth	Whether the warnings target attachment, structural injustice or wealth itself	Blessing as evidence of favor in the Crownward

Fault line	What's actually in dispute	Where TKC touches it
Purity and the body	Which regulations are ritual and which are moral, and who gets to sort them. The distinction is a later category applied to the texts, not a label printed in them.	The Designation, the Salt Ceremony, fertility review
The end of things	Whether apocalyptic writing addresses its own moment, a future program, a recurring pattern, or worship	Whose reading is orthodox and whose is sedition

[DESIGN NOTE: The fault-line table works as a full-width matrix with a fourth column left blank for "Where the Empire lands."]

I.7 Worked example: the household code (Ephesians 5:21–6:9)

Ephesians 5 is one of the passages most often cited in Christian teaching on marriage and male headship. The Empire's official line, "the husband leads, the wife supports, the household reflects divine order in miniature" (CR), is a version of one reading of it. Your files don't say which verses the Temple cites.

The letter. Ephesians presents itself as Paul writing to congregations in the Roman province of Asia. The words "in Ephesus" in 1:1 are missing from some of the earliest manuscripts (P46, Sinaiticus, Vaticanus), so many scholars think it was a circular letter. CONTESTED: Many critical scholars think a follower of Paul wrote it after his death, citing differences in vocabulary, style and theology from the seven letters nearly everyone accepts as his (Romans, 1–2 Corinthians, Galatians, Philippians, 1 Thessalonians, Philemon). Others defend Pauline authorship. This matters for any argument that sets Ephesians 5 against Romans 16, where Paul greets women who lead and work in the churches.

The shape of the passage. The household instructions come at the end of a long sentence that begins in 5:18 with "be filled with the Spirit." A series of participles follows: speaking to one another in psalms, singing, giving thanks, and in 5:21, "submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ."

Verses	Addressed to	In summary
5:21	Everyone	Submit to one another out of reverence for Christ

Verses	Addressed to	In summary
5:22–24	Wives	Submit to your husbands as to the Lord. The husband is head of the wife as Christ is head of the church. "In everything."
5:25–33	Husbands	Love your wives as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her. Love them as your own bodies, and nourish and cherish them. Quotes Genesis 2:24.
6:1–3	Children	Obey your parents
6:4	Fathers	Don't provoke your children to anger
6:5–8	Slaves	Obey your earthly masters with fear and sincerity, as you would Christ
6:9	Masters	Do the same to them, stop threatening, and remember you share a Master in heaven

The husbands' section is the longest in the code. One count makes it about 116 Greek words to the wives' 40 (Mowczko). Husbands are commanded to love, three times (5:25, 28, 33), and they're never told to rule, enforce or correct. The headship sentence (5:23) is addressed to wives.

The missing verb. The earliest manuscripts disagree about whether 5:22 has its own verb. P46 and Codex Vaticanus have none, and Clement of Alexandria quotes it that way, so the verse borrows "submitting" from 5:21. Codex Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus and many others add "let them submit" (*hypotassesthōsan*). Most later Byzantine manuscripts add "submit" (*hypotassesthe*). CONTESTED: Bruce Metzger's committee preferred the verbless reading, and Peter Gurry argues in *New Testament Studies* (2021) that *hypotassesthōsan* is original. Either way, 5:22 grows out of 5:21. The real disagreement is over what that connection means. The old Companion listed Sinaiticus as verbless, and that's wrong.

"Head" (*kephalē*). CONTESTED, and argued in print since the 1950s.

- **Source.** Stephen Bedale (1954) started the modern debate with "source or origin." Jerome Murphy-O'Connor, Catherine Kroeger and Philip Payne took it further.
- **Authority over.** Wayne Grudem surveyed 2,336 instances (*Trinity Journal*, 1985) and argued that "authority over" is well attested and "source" is rare. Joseph Fitzmyer (1989) agreed.

- **Prominence.** Richard Cervin's reply to Grudem (1989) is usually grouped with readings like "prominence" or "preeminence."

INTERPRETATION: The senses overlap more than the debate's tone suggests. What isn't in dispute is the text itself, which defines the husband's role by self-giving and by nourishing, and never tells him to exercise authority.

"Submit" (*hypotassō*). The verb means to arrange oneself under someone. The New Testament uses it for citizens toward governing authorities (Romans 13:1), slaves toward masters (Titus 2:9), the Son toward the Father (1 Corinthians 15:28), and in Ephesians 5:21 everyone toward everyone. INTERPRETATION: The middle voice is often read as describing something the subject does herself, but scholars disagree about how much weight that can bear. A voluntary act under a legal system where refusal is ruinous is voluntary only in a limited sense.

The household-code form. Aristotle's *Politics* (Book I) organizes household management around three pairs, master and slave, husband and wife, father and children, with the male head ruling each, and treats the household as the basic unit of the state. The New Testament has versions in Colossians 3:18–4:1, Ephesians 5:21–6:9 and 1 Peter 2:18–3:7. David Balch (*Let Wives Be Submissive*, 1981) argued that 1 Peter's code helped present the movement as respectable to suspicious outsiders. Ephesians departs from Aristotle by addressing wives, children and slaves directly as moral agents, by giving the stronger party obligations, and by grounding the arrangement in Christ instead of nature.

Reading	What it holds	Its hardest problem
Ordered roles (complementarian)	The husband leads and the wife submits, and they're equal in worth	Nothing in the passage tells a husband to enforce anything, and 5:21 addresses everyone
Mutual submission (egalitarian)	5:21 governs the whole section	The instructions are still asymmetrical, and only wives are told to submit
Historically situated	A minority movement taught to live inside Roman household law	It needs a principle for deciding what carries over to other centuries
Accommodation	A step back from the earlier practice of Paul's undisputed letters	It depends on unsettled questions of authorship and dating

In American history. Proslavery preachers quoted the slave instruction in the same code (6:5) constantly, and enslaved and free Black Christians and abolitionists answered with Exodus, Galatians 3:28 and the prophets. In 1807 a London society printed *Parts of the Holy Bible, Selected for the Use of the Negro Slaves, in the British West-India Islands*. It kept 232 of the 1,189 chapters of a standard Protestant Bible, kept Ephesians 6:5, and dropped Galatians 3:28 (NPR, 2018). The modern American debate over Ephesians 5 took its current form in 1987, with the Danvers Statement (complementarian) and the founding of Christians for Biblical Equality (egalitarian). Those dates still need checking against primary sources.

For TKC

INFERENCE: The Empire's scripture is in King James wording. Bell reads Proverbs 31:29 from the Book of Covenant as "Many daughters have done virtuously, but thou excellest them all" (DR3), which is the KJV text. A Bible shaped in part by a king's dislike of seditious margin notes is a fitting inheritance for an empire.

The Empire's official marriage theology is the ordered-roles reading, taken further than the passage goes. Male headship is written into civil law, enforced at the counter, and attached to a Binding no one has to consent to (CR, DR3, DOM). See Part IX.

POSSIBLE: The Empire never has to change the canon. The old Companion listed six instruments that are all documented somewhere in history and none of which touches a word of scripture: the calendar, the public readings, clergy training, schoolbooks, regional editions with their own notes, and Broadcast commentary. A book can be fully canonical and still never read aloud, as Revelation is in Orthodox worship.

POSSIBLE: The Temple's public reading of the household code starts at 5:22 and leaves out 5:21. That changes the passage's meaning without changing a word.

Working questions

1. Which collection is the Book of Covenant: the 66, the 73, or something else? Does it have notes, and who wrote them?
2. Which passages are read aloud in Aurem's Temples, and which books are in the Book of Covenant but never read?
3. Does any character own a different Bible: a Geneva, a Catholic edition, one with the Apocrypha, or an old study Bible with footnotes? What happens if it's found?
4. How does the Empire's schoolbook tell the story of how the Bible came to be?
5. Which of the eight fault lines does Eden first notice from the inside, and in what scene?

6. Who in the cast can read Greek or Hebrew, and who learned it, and where?
7. Does the Temple print 5:21 in its household teaching, and how does it handle 6:5–9, the slave instructions, in Aurem?
8. Which unsupported claim (category 4) does the Empire teach as settled fact?

[DESIGN NOTE: A full-page handwriting workspace after these questions.]

Part II. The books

This part is a working map of the library: a short entry for every book, then longer studies of the books TKC leans on hardest. The old Companion gave most books a full page. Here the quick map is compressed into two tables, and the depth goes to the focused studies (II.2) and the four Torah deep dives (II.3).

II.1 The sixty-six books: a quick map

In the last column, every TKC use is POSSIBLE unless it carries a source tag.

The Hebrew Bible / Old Testament (39 books, in Protestant order)

Book	What it is	What it argues about	Where TKC might use it
Genesis	Origins, then one family across four generations. No state, no priesthood, only households.	Blessing as something scarce that's won or stolen. Naming as authority. Whether obedience is trust or terror (the binding of Isaac is left without comment).	Hagar, the first person in scripture to give God a name (16:13). Sister rivalry. See II.3.
Exodus	A labor population inside an empire, an escape, a covenant at a mountain	Whether freedom is the point or only the precondition for law. It doesn't soften the deaths of Egypt's firstborn.	Two midwives disobey a royal order and are named while the king isn't (1:15–21). DR3 uses 20:12 in the Assessment. See II.3.

Book	What it is	What it argues about	Where TKC might use it
Leviticus	Priestly law: sacrifice, purity, holiness, festivals	Holiness as separation, and the machinery needed to maintain it. It also contains the Jubilee (ch. 25).	The vocabulary of a surveillance theocracy: clean, unclean, permitted, withheld. See II.3.
Numbers	Two censuses and a generation dying in the wilderness	Legitimate authority and the cost of questioning it. Korah is swallowed by the ground, and Zelophehad's daughters win their petition (ch. 27).	A census as a tool of control. The Torah's precedent for women changing a law by asking. See II.2.
Deuteronomy	Moses' farewell speeches. The law restated for a settled people.	The retribution formula: obey and prosper, disobey and lose the land. It also limits the king (ch. 17) and releases debts (ch. 15).	The Empire's founding logic, ready-made. The law of the king indicts an emperor by inventory. See II.3.
Joshua	The conquest of Canaan and the division of the land	Whether divine promise licenses violence. Whether belonging is blood or allegiance (Rahab and the Gibeonites are kept).	Rahab, a woman with no standing who reads a political situation faster than her whole city. Achan as the case for collective punishment (ch. 7).
Judges	A cycle of apostasy, oppression and deliverance, each turn worse	Whether life without a king is freedom or collapse. It argues for monarchy by showing what happens to women when nobody's in charge.	Deborah's unquestioned authority. The closing verse (21:25) as an Empire slogan. The woman of chapter 19.

Book	What it is	What it argues about	Where TKC might use it
Ruth	Four chapters about two widows, set in the same era as Judges	Who belongs. A Moabite woman is written into David's line on purpose.	The most famous vow of devotion in scripture is spoken by a woman to a woman (1:16).
1–2 Samuel	The founding of the monarchy: Samuel, Saul, David	Whether an anointed king can be held to account. The text keeps David's crimes in.	Samuel's itemized warning about what a king will take (1 Sam 8). Nathan's "You are the man" (2 Sam 12:7). Tamar's case buried to protect the dynasty (2 Sam 13).
1–2 Kings	The kingdom from Solomon's temple to its destruction	Why the state fell, answered theologically: the kings were unfaithful	Naboth's vineyard, a man killed by correct legal procedure (1 Kgs 21). Huldah authenticating a scroll for the king (2 Kgs 22). The widow's oil (2 Kgs 4), used in DR3's Assessment.
1–2 Chronicles	The same monarchy retold after the exile	Lineage and legitimacy. David's affair with Bathsheba and Absalom's revolt are left out.	Two official histories of one reign, one of them cleaned up. See II.2.
Ezra	A return from exile under Persian license, a rebuilt temple, then a purity crisis	Belonging. The community is told to send away foreign wives and their children (ch. 9–10).	Ethnic purity legislated as obedience. See II.2.
Nehemiah	A Persian official rebuilds Jerusalem's walls	Walls, registers and enforcement, plus a debt crisis where the poor are pledging their children (ch. 5)	A reformer aimed at his own class. See II.2.

Book	What it is	What it argues about	Where TKC might use it
Esther	A Jewish orphan becomes queen of Persia. God is never named in the Hebrew text.	How to act with no power and no guarantee. Its ethics are improvised, and it never says whether they're admirable.	A state search that gathers young women for a year of preparation (ch. 2). Vashti, who says no in chapter one. DR3's Assessment uses Esther's crown.
Job	A blameless man loses everything, and three friends explain why he deserved it	Whether suffering is earned. God rebukes the friends who defended him with correct doctrine (42:7).	Scripture's own proof that the pious answer can be wrong.
Psalms	150 songs and prayers for worship, assembled over centuries	Whether God can be addressed honestly. About a third, by common counts, are laments.	The liturgy bank. Lament gives a character a sanctioned way to say the unsayable in public. *Selah* appears seventy-one times here.
Proverbs	Instruction for young men entering public life	Wisdom as learnable and generally rewarded. Wisdom herself is a woman present at creation (ch. 8).	The register of Imperial advice literature. Proverbs 31 is printed on the Assessment and read before the scores (DR3).
Ecclesiastes	A man with everything tests every route to meaning	Whether anything lasts. Its answer is *hevel*, vapor.	The voice of a courtier who's stopped believing the palace means anything. See II.2.
Song of Songs	Love poetry with no mention of God	Desire. The woman speaks most of the lines and is never rebuked.	Desire with scriptural standing. CONTESTED: human love poetry or allegory.

Book	What it is	What it argues about	Where TKC might use it
Isaiah	A prophetic scroll covering the Assyrian crisis, the exile and the return	Whether God's people are the point or the instrument. It keeps widening the circle, to foreigners and to eunuchs. CONTESTED: Most scholars see three sets of authors, and traditional readers one.	"Your hands are full of blood" (1:15). The suffering servant, a model of power the Empire can't use.
Jeremiah	Forty years of telling a capital it would fall	True prophecy against the licensed prophets, who promise the city can't be taken	Stocks, a cistern, a treason trial, and a scroll burned by the king and dictated again (ch. 36).
Lamentations	Five poems over the ruins of Jerusalem. Four are alphabetical acrostics.	Grief that refuses easy resolution	The register for the book's worst chapter. Scripture the Empire can't ban and can't use.
Ezekiel	Visions of a deported priest	Whether God can leave the temple. Whether guilt is inherited (ch. 18 says no).	The shepherds who fed themselves (ch. 34). See II.2.
Daniel	Court stories, then apocalyptic visions	Integrity inside a regime that owns your career. CONTESTED: Most critical scholars date the visions to the persecution of the 160s BCE, and traditional readers date the book to the sixth century.	The manual for a character inside Imperial service. Serve well, refuse at one exact point, and make the refusal public.

Book	What it is	What it argues about	Where TKC might use it
Hosea	A prophet's marriage staged as national metaphor	Covenant as marriage, tender and disturbing at once	The theology underneath the Empire's language of wifely duty
Joel	A locust plague read as the day of the Lord	The spirit poured out on sons and daughters, old and young, and servants (2:28–29)	Prophecy democratized. A problem for any institution with a monopoly on speaking.
Amos	A herdsman from Judah preaching in prosperous Israel	Economic injustice. "I hate, I despise your festivals" (5:21).	The most quotable indictment of a comfortable religious state
Obadiah	One chapter against Edom	Complicity: standing by and profiting while a city falls	The bystander Dominion
Jonah	A prophet runs from his assignment and resents God's mercy to the enemy	Mercy extended to the enemy, and a believer who can't bear it	Satire inside scripture
Micah	Judgment on rulers who "eat the flesh of my people" (3:3)	Do justice, love mercy, walk humbly (6:8)	Three phrases that fit on a wall and indict whoever owns the wall
Nahum	The fall of Nineveh, the Assyrian capital	An empire's end, celebrated	What the provinces sing when the center burns
Habakkuk	A prophet argues with God about injustice	Faith as an argument you lose and stay in	*Selah* appears in its closing prayer (ch. 3)
Zephaniah	A day of judgment, officials named first	A purge with a humble remnant left	The purge sermon aimed at the Temple itself
Haggai	Rebuild the temple	State religion as a construction project	Religion and public works

Book	What it is	What it argues about	Where TKC might use it
Zechariah	Night visions, and a king who rides a donkey (9:9)	Power that refuses the warhorse	Ceremony as legitimacy
Malachi	Disputations with priests and people after the return	An audit of the priesthood, and men discarding their wives (2:14–16)	Corrupt clergy on the record in the Empire's own book. In Christian order it's the last book of the Old Testament.

Correction to the old Companion: it said "the last word of the Old Testament is an accusation against clergy." Malachi's closing verses are a promise about Elijah and a warning. The audit of the priests comes earlier, in chapters 1–2.

The New Testament (27 books)

Book	What it is	What it argues about	Where TKC might use it
Matthew	A Gospel built in five teaching blocks, with heavy use of scripture	Jesus as the fulfillment of the Law. The genealogy names four women.	The Sermon on the Mount, the Lord's Prayer (6:9–13), and a whole chapter denouncing religious leaders by title (ch. 23)
Mark	The earliest and shortest Gospel	Discipleship as misunderstanding. The earliest manuscripts end at 16:8, with women fleeing the tomb afraid.	An ending later scribes found too abrupt and added to
Luke	A Gospel attentive to women, foreigners and the poor	Reversal. Mary's song (1:46–55). Jesus' first sermon announces release (4:16–30).	Names the women who funded the movement (8:1–3). See Part IV.

Book	What it is	What it argues about	Where TKC might use it
John	Long discourses, seven signs, high theology	Who Jesus is	His longest conversation is with a Samaritan woman (ch. 4). Mary Magdalene is the first witness sent to tell the men (ch. 20).
Acts	The early movement, from Jerusalem to Rome	Who's allowed in, and who decides (ch. 15). Shared property (2:44–45).	An unlicensed network meeting in women's houses (Lydia, ch. 16).
Romans	Paul's longest letter	Who belongs to God's people and on what basis	Romans 13 on authorities. Phoebe the deacon carried it, and Junia is greeted as "prominent among the apostles" (16:1–7).
1 Corinthians	A divided congregation	Status, food, sex, worship and resurrection	The silence passage (14:34–35). CONTESTED: Some manuscripts place those verses after 14:40.
2 Corinthians	Paul defends his ministry	Authority through weakness	
Galatians	A furious letter about Gentile converts and the Law	Whether outsiders must assimilate to belong. "No longer slave or free, no longer male and female" (3:28).	The verse the 1807 Slave Bible removed (Part V)
Ephesians	A letter on the church as one body	Unity, plus the household code (5:21–6:9). CONTESTED authorship.	See I.7.

Book	What it is	What it argues about	Where TKC might use it
Philippians	Written from prison	Joy, and a hymn about power surrendered (2:5–11)	
Colossians	Christ over all powers, with a household code (3:18–4:1)	CONTESTED authorship	
1 Thessalonians	Paul's earliest surviving letter	The return of Christ	
2 Thessalonians	Correcting speculation about the end	CONTESTED authorship	
1 Timothy	Church order	Who may teach and lead. The restriction on women teaching (2:11–15). Enrolled widows (ch. 5).	The Temple's clergy handbook. CONTESTED authorship, along with the other Pastorals.
2 Timothy	A farewell letter from prison	Faithfulness under pressure	
Titus	Appointing elders	Order in households and churches	
Philemon	A short letter about Onesimus, an enslaved man	What a believer owes an enslaved brother	Argued over by both sides in the abolition debate
Hebrews	An anonymous sermon-letter	The old sacrificial system fulfilled	Nearly all scholars agree Paul didn't write it
James	Practical wisdom	Faith that does nothing, favoritism toward the rich (2:1–7), and withheld wages (5:4)	The bluntest economic text in the New Testament

Book	What it is	What it argues about	Where TKC might use it
1 Peter	To believers scattered and suspected	Endurance as outsiders, with a household code (2:18–3:7)	Balch's "respectability" reading (I.7)
2 Peter	Warnings about false teachers	The delay of the end	The most doubted book in antiquity (I.2)
1 John	Love and truth	Who is really in the community	
2 John	A short letter to "the elect lady"	Hospitality and false teachers	
3 John	A short letter to Gaius	A local power struggle over hospitality	
Jude	One chapter against intruders	Faithfulness. Quotes 1 Enoch.	
Revelation	Visions written from Patmos to seven churches under Rome	Whether empires end. The throne belongs to a slaughtered lamb (ch. 5).	Marks, seals, beasts, a bride and a city mourned by its merchants (ch. 18). "Come out of her, my people" (18:4).

[DESIGN NOTE: The two tables could become a fold-out map of the library: books as blocks sized by chapter count, colored by genre, with the TKC-relevant ones outlined.]

II.2 Focused studies

These seven books get more than a line because TKC uses them as raw material: registers, petitions, licensed religion, court advice, a prophet whose body becomes the message, and twelve short books that argue with power. The old Companion's later spreads on these books were its most careful work, and several of them corrected its own earlier claims. Those corrections are kept.

Numbers: counting, the camp, and two petitions

The English name comes from the book's two censuses. The Hebrew name, *Bemidbar*, means "in the wilderness." The book moves in three stages: Sinai (chapters 1–10), the wilderness (11–21) and the plains of Moab (22–36).

The census. It counts men twenty and older who can fight, by ancestral house. Women and children aren't counted, and the Levites are registered separately. The totals are 603,550 in chapter 1 and 601,730 in chapter 26. Taken literally, that implies a population in the millions. CONTESTED: Proposals include a different meaning for the word translated "thousand," schematic totals, and later expansion. None is settled. By chapter 26 the whole first generation is dead except Caleb and Joshua (26:64–65). The camp in chapter 2 assigns every tribe a fixed position on four sides around the tabernacle, and the same arrangement is reproduced at every stop.

Miriam and Aaron (ch. 12). Both speak against Moses. Verse 1 uses a feminine singular verb while naming both of them, and verse 2 shifts to the plural. The occasion is Moses' Cushite wife, but the claim is about prophetic authority: has the LORD spoken only through Moses? Only Miriam is struck with a skin disease. Aaron pleads for her, and she's shut outside the camp for seven days. The people don't move on until she's brought back. The text never explains why only she is marked.

Two petitions. Korah's revolt (ch. 16) and the petition of Zelophehad's daughters (ch. 27) are a matched pair.

	Korah, ch. 16	Zelophehad's daughters, ch. 27
Who	Korah the Levite, Dathan, Abiram and 250 men of standing	Mahlah, Noah, Hoglah, Milcah and Tirzah, each named
What they ask for	Priestly access, contesting Aaron's office	Their dead father's inheritance, since he had no sons
How they ask	An assembly against Moses and Aaron, then a censer test	They stand before Moses, Eleazar, the chiefs and the whole congregation and state their case
Outcome	The ground opens, and fire consumes the 250	Granted, and made a general law of inheritance
Afterward	The sons of Korah survive as singers named in the Psalms headings	Chapter 36 fences the win: they must marry within their father's tribe

INTERPRETATION: The pair shows which petitions an authority can hear. A petition that works through the system's own procedure, asks for a defined thing and leaves the office alone can be granted and written into law. One that contests the office gets the ground.

The wilderness middle. Ten scouts report the land can't be taken, and two dissent. The generation that believed the ten is denied entry. Moses complains at length and isn't punished. The bronze serpent Moses made at God's command (21:4–9) is destroyed centuries later by Hezekiah because people had started making offerings to it (2 Kgs 18:4), so a commanded object becomes one that has to be destroyed. The Balaam of chapters 22–24 blesses Israel, while later texts treat him as a villain. Joshua is commissioned publicly, by laying on of hands, while Moses is still alive (27:12–23).

1–2 Chronicles: the retelling

The Hebrew title means "the events of the days." The Greek tradition called it *Paraleipomena*, "things left out." It's anonymous and generally dated to the Persian period. Whether the same writer produced Ezra–Nehemiah was long assumed and is now widely doubted. In the Jewish order it's the last book of the Bible, ending with Cyrus telling the exiles to go up. In Christian Bibles it sits after Kings.

It opens with nine chapters of genealogy, then David, Solomon and the temple, then the kings of Judah only, down to the exile. It draws on Samuel and Kings, often word for word.

Material	What Chronicles does with it
Bathsheba and Uriah	The story is left out. Bathsheba herself stays, in David's genealogy as Solomon's mother (1 Chr 3:5, as Bath-shua).
Amnon, Tamar and Absalom	Not retold
David's census	Kept, with the plague. Samuel says the LORD incited David (2 Sam 24:1), while Chronicles says an adversary did (1 Chr 21:1).
Levites, singers and musicians	Added at length, with guilds, rotas and duties
Hezekiah's Passover	Added, with invitations sent to the north
Manasseh	Added: Judah's worst king is taken to Babylon, prays and is restored (2 Chr 33:10–20)

Correction to the old Companion: its early page said "Bathsheba is gone." The affair is gone, and she isn't.

The genealogies name more women than their reputation suggests. Sheerah builds three towns (7:24). Sheshan's daughter marries his Egyptian servant, and the line is traced through them (2:34–35). Bithiah, a daughter of Pharaoh, appears as a wife (4:18), and Jabez's mother names him (4:9).

INTERPRETATION: "Cover-up" is one way to read the omissions. Another is a history written for worship, not for judgment, for readers who already knew the older account, which Chronicles cites. Hold both, and say which one you're using.

Ezra: restoration under license

Ezra and Nehemiah were transmitted as one book in the Hebrew tradition. Chapters 1–6 cover the first returns and the rebuilt temple, decades before Ezra appears. Chapters 7–10 bring Ezra, a priest and scribe sent from Babylon with a royal commission, and the crisis over intermarriage. Part of the book (4:8–6:18, 7:12–26) is in Aramaic, the Persian administrative language, and much of it is correspondence. CONTESTED: Whether the documents are authentic, edited or composed is debated.

Nothing happens without imperial authorization. Cyrus issues the decree, and the temple vessels are counted back out of a royal treasury (ch. 1). A returnee register decides standing on arrival, and families who can't document their descent are kept from the

priesthood until a ruling (2:59–63). At the foundation-laying, the young shout and the old weep, and the noise can't be told apart (3:12–13). The work is stopped by a letter calling the rebuilding a security risk. An archive search halts construction, and a later search reverses it (chs. 4–6). Local people who offer to help build are turned away (4:1–3).

In chapters 9–10, men of the community, priests and Levites included, are found to have married women of the surrounding peoples. An assembly agrees to send away the wives and the children born to them, a commission examines cases household by household, and about a hundred men are listed. A few men object (10:15). No woman speaks or is named, and nothing records where they went. The book simply stops. CONTESTED: Whether "foreign" means ethnic, religious or a land dispute between returnees and those who never left, and whether the policy was carried out fully.

The old Companion's later spread refused the phrase "ethnic cleansing with a liturgy" because it imports a modern legal category into a text whose scale and terms are disputed. That refusal is kept here, and the ethical problem stays on the page in full.

Nehemiah: walls, registers and a debt crisis

Nehemiah is cupbearer to the Persian king, a trusted court office with personal access, and then governor of the province. Much of the book is a first-person memoir with lists and documents set into it. He arrives with letters of safe passage, a timber requisition and a cavalry escort (2:7–9). He inspects the ruined walls at night and tells no one (2:11–16). The wall goes up in fifty-two days (6:15), built by named crews that include priests, goldsmiths, perfumers and one official working with his daughters (3:12). Half the workers are armed while the other half build (4:16). The opposition works through ridicule, invitations to a trap, an open letter accusing him of wanting to be king, and a hired prophet (ch. 6). Once the wall stands, he sets gate hours and immediately convenes a genealogical enrollment (ch. 7).

Chapter 5 interrupts the building for a debt crisis. People and their wives raise a great outcry. Some have mortgaged fields to buy grain, some have borrowed to pay the king's tax, and their children are being enslaved for debt, daughters first. The creditors are the community's own nobles and officials. Nehemiah confronts them publicly, orders the fields, houses and interest restored, makes them swear before the priests, and gives up his governor's food allowance.

INTERPRETATION: The people say they borrowed to pay the king's tax. The reform reaches the local creditor and never the empire behind the tax.

The middle of the book is a day-long public reading of the law to men and women, with Levites "giving the sense" (8:8). CONTESTED: Whether that includes translating into Aramaic. Then comes a sealed covenant with named signers (ch. 10). The book ends with enforcement. A temple room given to an outsider is cleared. Sabbath trade is shut down by locking the gates. Nehemiah reports contending with men over their marriages, cursing them, striking some and pulling out their hair (13:25), and driving out a high priest's grandson married into a rival governor's family (13:28).

Ecclesiastes: the court passages

The Hebrew name, *Qohelet*, means roughly "the one who assembles." It's a role, not a personal name. The speaker is "son of David, king in Jerusalem," but Solomon is never named. CONTESTED: Most scholars date the Hebrew well after Solomon, to the Persian or Hellenistic period. A third-person epilogue (12:9–14) frames the book, and readers disagree over whether it endorses, domesticates or corrects what came before.

The word the book turns on is *hevel*, which appears about thirty-eight times. Its concrete sense is vapor or breath, something real that won't stay in your hand.

Rendering	The book it produces
"Vanity" (KJV, from the Latin *vanitas*)	Sounds like a sermon against pride, which isn't the sense
"Meaningless"	The strongest rendering and the most misleading, since the book keeps recommending things
"Futile"	Fits the labor passages and fits the enjoyment passages badly
"Vapor" or "breath"	Keeps the image. It shares its consonants with Abel's name in Genesis 4.

The book also tells its reader again and again to eat, drink, find good in work and enjoy life with the person you love (2:24, 3:13, 5:18, 9:7–9). A summary that keeps only the bleak half isn't a summary of this book.

The political passages read like someone who's watched government from inside. The oppressed have "no one to comfort them" (4:1). The difficult verses about one official watching over another (5:8–9) are translated very differently. "Keep the king's command"

(8:2–4) is grounded in the fact that he has power, not that he has a right. "Do not curse the king, even in your thought… for a bird of the air shall carry the voice" (10:20). "The race is not to the swift" (9:11) directly denies that the strong reliably win.

INTERPRETATION: Fatalism is useful to a government: if nothing can change, nothing needs changing. It also protects people. A woman who believes the outcome was never hers to decide can survive a verdict that would otherwise destroy her.

Ezekiel: a priest in exile

Ezekiel, son of Buzi, is a priest deported to Babylonia in an early wave, about a decade before Jerusalem and the temple fall (1:1–3). His whole recorded ministry takes place in exile. He dates his oracles by years since King Jehoiachin was deported, not by Babylonian reigns. The book has three movements: judgment before the fall (1–24), oracles against the nations (25–32), and restoration after the fall (33–48).

He's made into a demonstration. He lies on one side and then the other for a set number of days, eats siege rations, shaves his head and divides the hair, and digs through a wall at dusk with a packed bag (chs. 4–5, 12). The divine glory leaves the temple in stages, from the sanctuary to the threshold to the east gate and out of the city (chs. 8–11), and returns by the same gate to a rebuilt house (ch. 43). He's told in advance that his wife, "the delight of your eyes," will die, and that he must not mourn her publicly, as a sign. She dies, and he obeys (24:15–27). The text gives her no name and no words.

Chapters 16 and 23 cast Jerusalem, and Samaria and Jerusalem as two sisters, as unfaithful women whose punishment is described as stripping, exposure and violence. The imagery is explicit. A large body of modern scholarship, much of it feminist (Renita Weems, Julie Galambush), argues the violence can't be treated as incidental to the theological point. This entry doesn't quote it.

Chapter 18 rejects the exiles' proverb about sour grapes: the one who sins bears it, and a person who turns isn't held to their record. That sits against Exodus 20:5 and Lamentations 5:7. The shepherds of chapter 34 fed themselves, wore the wool, ruled with force and didn't seek the lost. God removes them, takes over the work personally, and then promises one shepherd, "my servant David." The dry bones of chapter 37 are interpreted in the text itself as the whole house of Israel, a people who believe they're finished. The last nine chapters are a measured temple and a redivided land. CONTESTED: Whether it's a blueprint, a vision or a protest.

The Twelve

In Jewish tradition the twelve short prophetic books are one book, written on a single scroll. "Minor" refers to their length. The Hebrew and Greek orders differ in the first six books, and the printed order isn't chronological.

Book	Setting	The power in the room
Amos	Northern kingdom, 8th century	Prosperity before Assyria. A Judean speaking in the north.
Hosea	Northern kingdom, 8th century	Assyrian pressure and collapse
Micah	Judah, 8th century	Assyrian campaigns. A rural voice against the capital.
Nahum	Judah, 7th century	Nineveh about to fall or newly fallen
Zephaniah	Judah, 7th century	Late Assyrian period. Aimed at officials and merchants.
Habakkuk	Judah, late 7th century	Babylon rising, named as God's instrument
Haggai	Persian period	Dated by a Persian king's reign. Rebuilding the temple.
Zechariah	Persian period, with later material	The same moment as Haggai in chapters 1–8
Jonah	Set in the Assyrian era	Generally thought to be written later
Joel	Uncertain	No king named
Obadiah	Uncertain	Most often tied to the aftermath of Jerusalem's fall
Malachi	Persian period	A functioning temple with slack practice. "Malachi" may be a title ("my messenger").

Some of the old Companion's own corrections are kept.

- **Amos.** He calls himself a herdsman and a dresser of sycamore figs (7:14), which isn't a poor farmer and possibly a man of some means. His reply to the priest Amaziah is usually read as denying that he belongs to the professional prophetic guild. The Hebrew is terse and argued over.

- **Hosea.** "A God who keeps taking the nation back" is accurate to the reconciliation passages, and it leaves out the mechanism, which is a husband's authorized violence. Say both or neither.
- **Joel 2:28–29.** The third group is translated as household servants in some versions and enslaved men and women in others. Check translations before quoting.
- **Jonah.** Satire is one strong genre classification, not settled fact. Parable and didactic novella are serious alternatives.
- **Micah 6:8.** "Do justice, love mercy, walk humbly" is the answer to a question about what offerings can buy, after chapters about land seizure (2:1–2) and prophets who "cry peace" when they're fed (3:5).
- **Habakkuk.** God's reply doesn't answer the question that was asked, and the book ends in waiting, with a psalm that chooses trust without claiming anything has improved.
- **Nahum.** It's the voice of people who lived under Assyrian terror, watching it end. The gendered humiliation of the city is doing real work too.
- **Malachi.** The closing verses are about Elijah and turning parents' and children's hearts toward each other, not about priests.

INTERPRETATION: The Twelve contains both kinds of prophet, the ones who tell an institution to finish its building (Haggai) and the ones who tell it its worship is worthless while it sells the poor (Amos 5:21–24). Any state that licenses a prophetic office is choosing from that range.

Micah offers a working test, as an application and not a command: prophets who "cry peace" while they're being fed (3:5). Follow the money, and see whose interest the message serves.

For TKC

- **The register as an instrument.** It appears in Numbers 1, the returnee list of Ezra 2, Chronicles' genealogies and Nehemiah 7, and it does a different job each time: muster, standing on arrival, continuity, enrollment. The Registry (Part VII.7) and the household authority line belong to the same family. POSSIBLE: Chronicles keeps a register to include a scattered people, and the Empire keeps one to rank a gathered one.
- **Numbers 27 and 36.** A successful petition by women that's immediately fenced. POSSIBLE: The Temple preaches Korah, and Zelophehad's daughters never appear in the schoolbook.

- **Ezra.** Religion licensed and funded by an empire, with the paperwork quoted. It's the closest biblical parallel to Governor-Prelates and a Temple that's also a branch of government.
- **Nehemiah 5.** Debt bondage of daughters inside the community, driven by the king's tax. POSSIBLE: This is the shape of an Imperial economy in which a household loses a daughter to debt.
- **Ecclesiastes 10:20.** A surveillance proverb already in the canon. POSSIBLE: The Temple teaches "keep the king's command" (8:2) as an endorsement and quotes only the last two verses of the book.
- **Ezekiel 18.** Guilt isn't inherited. That's a direct problem for a system that classifies children by household registration (FR 32) and punishes families for one member's offense.
- **Ezekiel 16 and 23.** The Empire already treats a woman's body as the place where a household's loyalty is measured. It has scriptural warrant for that, at length, in a major prophet. Whether the Temple quotes these chapters or keeps them from public reading is an open question.

Working questions

1. Who in Eden's world is counted, who is only registered, and who is on no list at all?
2. Which petition is Eden bringing, Korah's or the daughters'? Does she know which one it looks like to the Temple?
3. Is there an Imperial bronze serpent, a relic once commanded and now worshipped, that someone will eventually have to destroy?
4. Does the Empire have an official history and an older one, a Kings and a Chronicles? Who has read both?
5. Write one of the women sent away in Ezra 10. Give her a name and the sentence the text didn't give her.
6. How does a household in Aurem lose a daughter to debt? Write the mechanism.
7. Who in the cast believes Ecclesiastes' fatalism sincerely, and who teaches it knowing better?
8. Does the Empire inherit guilt by household or by person, and does it say the same thing every time?
9. Which of the Twelve is in the Temple's approved readings, and which is never read aloud?
10. Is there a prophet in the novel, licensed or not? Who decides?

[DESIGN NOTE: The Korah and Zelophehad comparison works as a side-by-side spread. A full-page handwriting workspace after these questions.]